Kondo and RKKY interactions in bilayer graphene

Aravindh Swaminathan Shankar

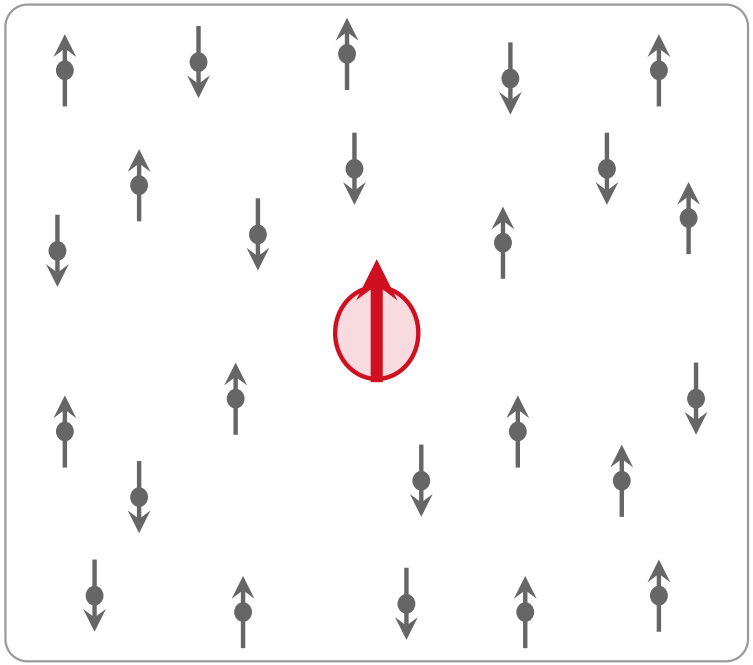
ashankar@ictp.it

with D. O. Oriekhov, L. Fritz, A. K. Mitchell

Abdus Salam ICTP, Trieste, Italy

NM4QM 2026

A magnetic impurity in a metal is screened away below T_K: the Kondo effect

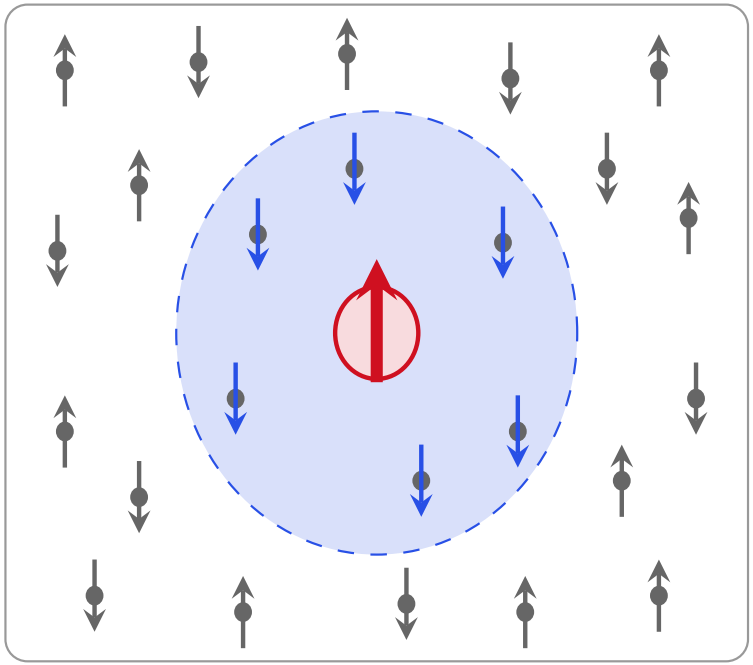


local moment

$$H = H_{\text{host}} + J\,\vec{S}\cdot\vec{s}(0)$$

Impurity spin coupled to the conduction electrons

A magnetic impurity in a metal is screened away below T_K: the Kondo effect



Kondo singlet

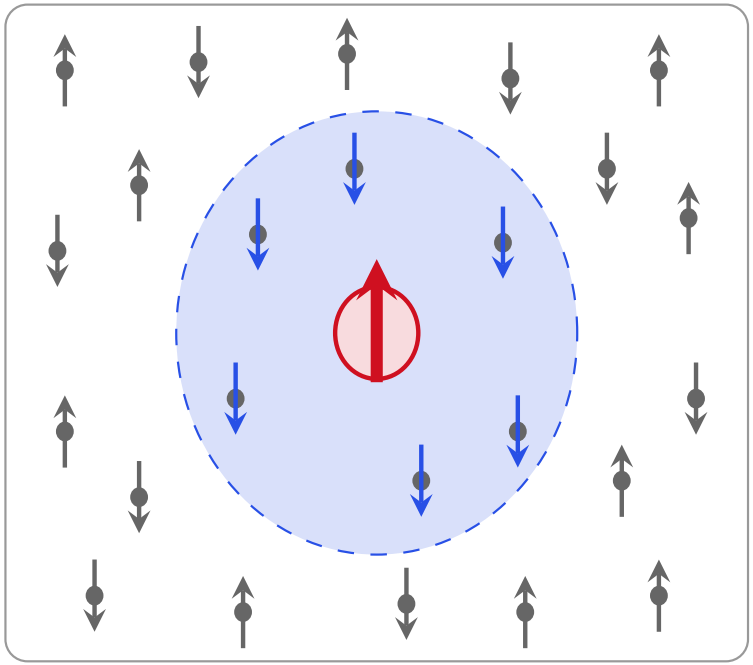
$$H = H_{\text{host}} + J\,\vec{S}\cdot\vec{s}(0)$$

Impurity spin coupled to the conduction electrons

Low T: the electrons rearrange and screen the moment

Strong coupling: beyond perturbation theory

A magnetic impurity in a metal is screened away below T_K: the Kondo effect



Kondo singlet

$$H = H_{\text{host}} + J\,\vec{S}\cdot\vec{s}(0)$$

Impurity spin coupled to the conduction electrons

Low T: the electrons rearrange and screen the moment

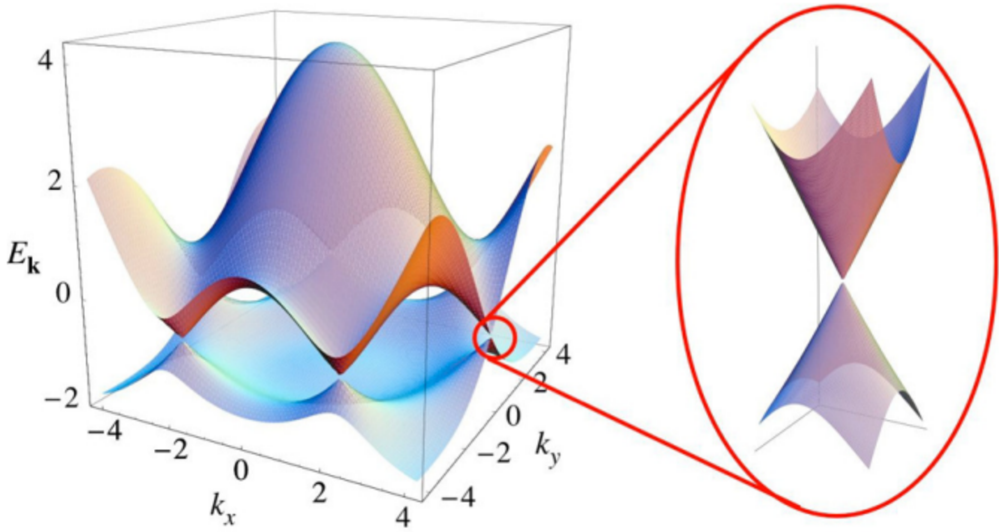
Strong coupling: beyond perturbation theory

$$T_K = D\,e^{-1/\rho_0 J}$$

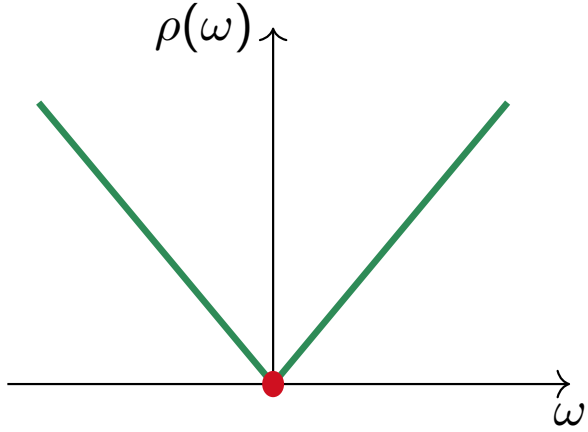
host density of states at the Fermi level

The host density of states decides if, and when, the moment is screened

No Kondo effect in graphene at charge neutrality



Castro Neto et al., Rev. Mod. Phys. 81, 109 (2009)



$\rho(E_F) = 0$

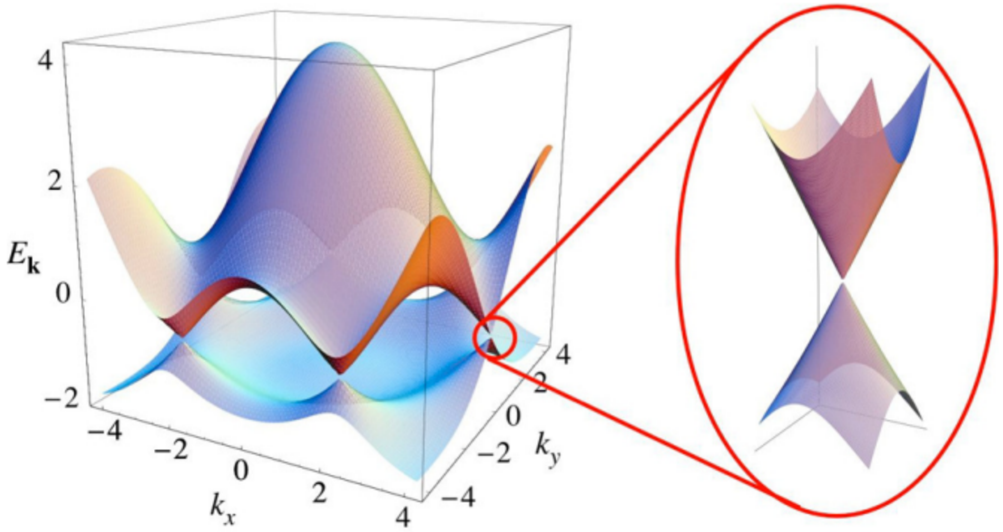
$$T_K = D\, e^{-1/\rho_0 J}$$

$\rho_0 \to 0 \;\Rightarrow\; T_K \to 0$

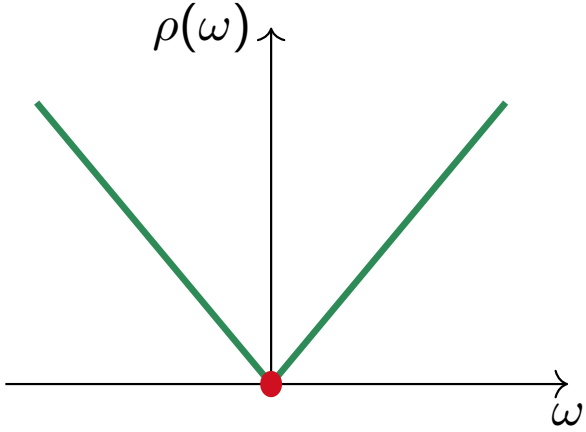
the moment stays free

What happens in other graphene-like materials?

No Kondo effect in graphene at charge neutrality



Castro Neto et al., Rev. Mod. Phys. 81, 109 (2009)



$\rho(E_F) = 0$

$$T_K = D\, e^{-1/\rho_0 J}$$

$\rho_0 \to 0 \;\Rightarrow\; T_K \to 0$

the moment stays free

Experiments in graphene

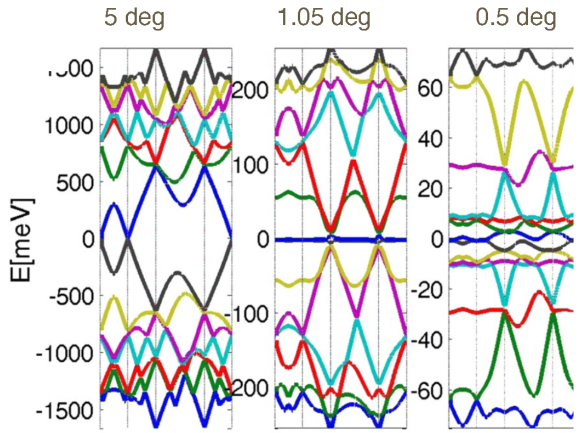
H adatoms: González-Herrero et al., Science 352, 437 (2016)
Vacancies: Jiang, . . . , Andrei, Nat. Commun. 9, 2349 (2018)

What happens in other graphene-like materials?

Model: Anderson impurity on twisted bilayer graphene

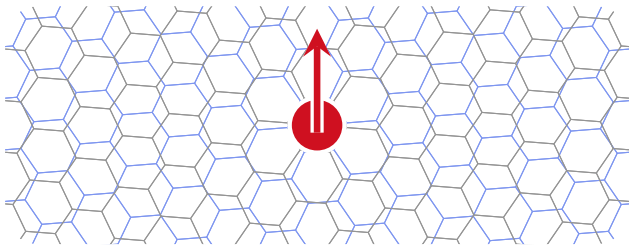
Host Bistritzer–MacDonald continuum model

$$H(\mathbf{k}) = \begin{pmatrix} h^K_{\theta/2}(\mathbf{k}) & wT_1 & wT_2 & wT_3 \\ wT_1^\dagger & h^K_{-\theta/2}(\mathbf{k}-\mathbf{q}_1) & 0 & 0 \\ wT_2^\dagger & 0 & h^K_{-\theta/2}(\mathbf{k}-\mathbf{q}_2) & 0 \\ wT_3^\dagger & 0 & 0 & h^K_{-\theta/2}(\mathbf{k}-\mathbf{q}_3) \end{pmatrix}$$



Bistritzer and MacDonald, PNAS 108, 12233 (2011)

Impurity Anderson model



$$H_{\text{imp}} = \epsilon_d \sum_\sigma n_{d\sigma} + U\, n_{d\uparrow} n_{d\downarrow} + V \sum_\sigma \left(d_\sigma^\dagger c_{0\sigma} + \text{h.c.} \right)$$

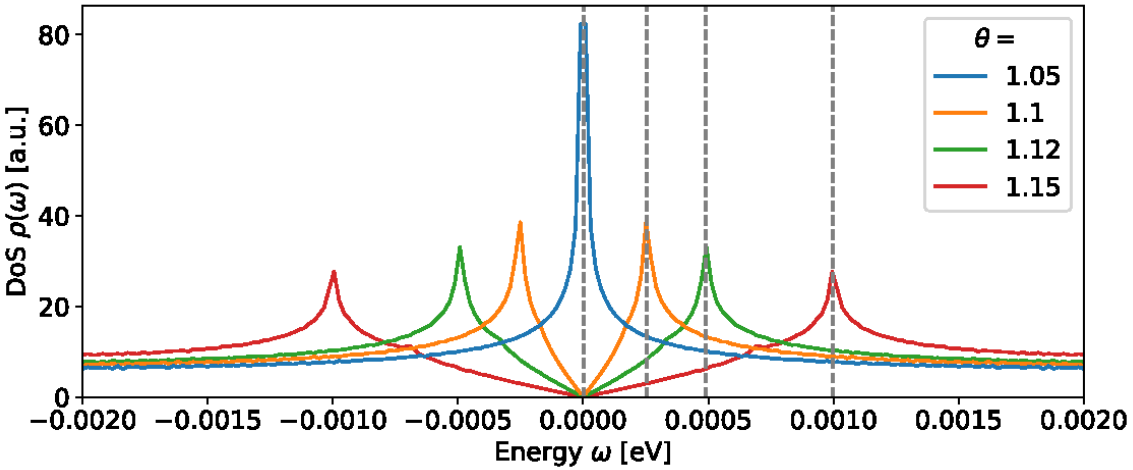
$|0\rangle$ $|\uparrow\rangle$ $|\downarrow\rangle$ $|\uparrow\downarrow\rangle$

4 states; large U leaves $\uparrow, \downarrow$:
a spin-$\frac{1}{2}$ moment, $J \sim V^2/U$

Impurities in TBG: Shankar, Oriekhov, Mitchell, Fritz, PRB 107, 245102 (2023);

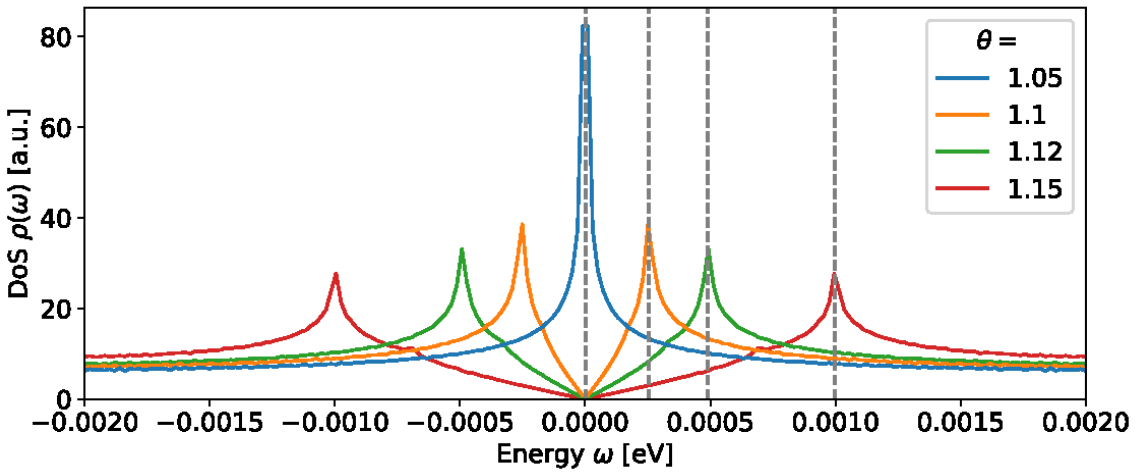
Chang, Yi, Wu, Kugler, Andrei, Vanderbilt, Kotliar, Pixley, PRL 133, 126503 (2024)

van Hove singularities in the flat band



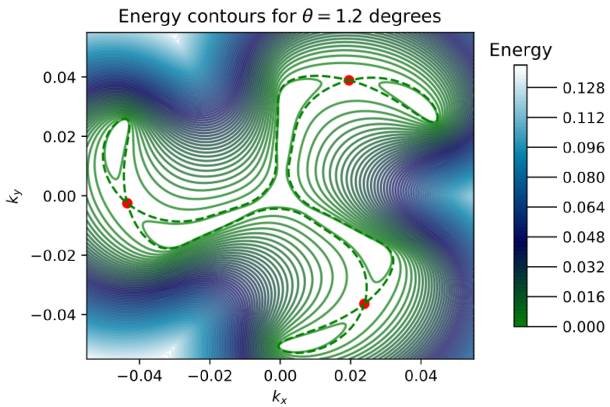
Dirac cone at $\omega = 0$: $\rho \sim |\omega|$

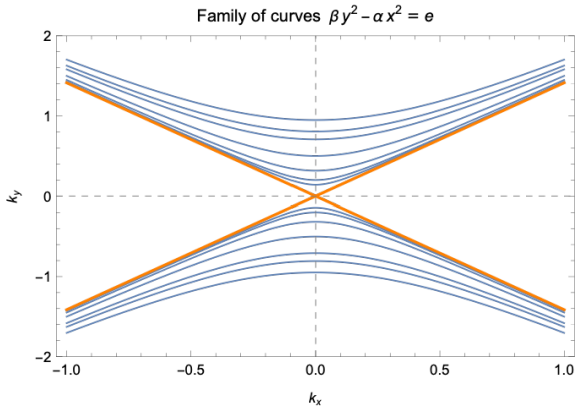
van Hove singularities in the flat band



Dirac cone at $\omega = 0$: $\rho \sim |\omega|$

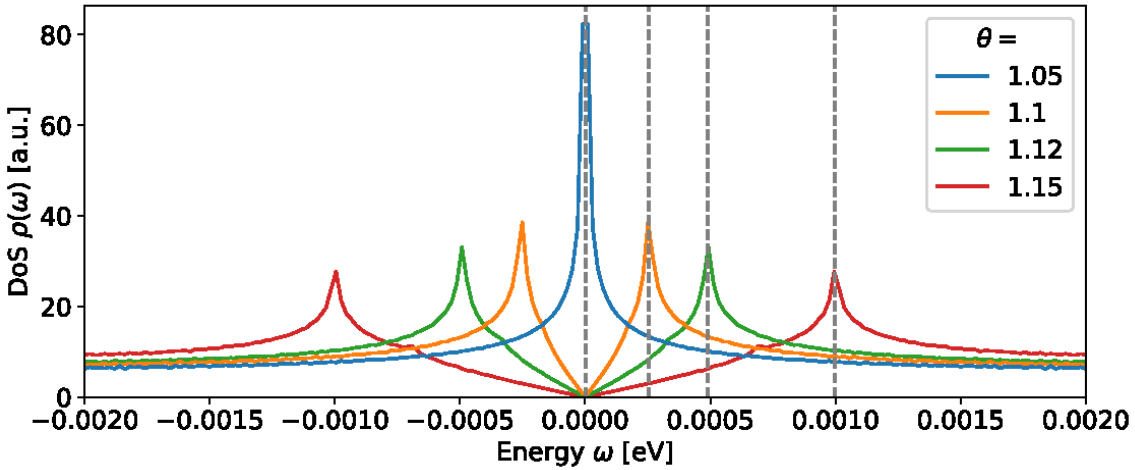
van Hove peaks at $\pm E_v$





ordinary saddle $\quad E = E_v + \alpha p_x^2 - \beta p_y^2 \implies \rho(E) \sim \log \left| \frac{\Lambda}{E - E_v} \right|$

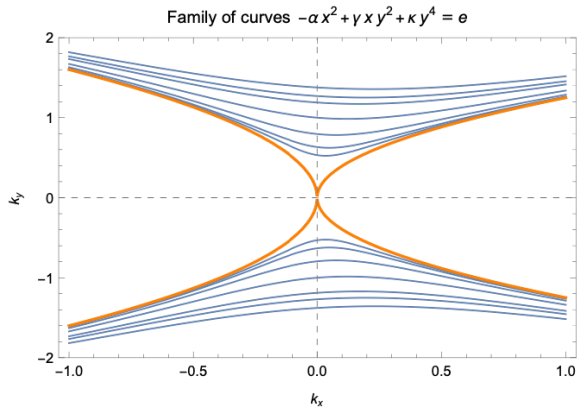
van Hove singularities in the flat band

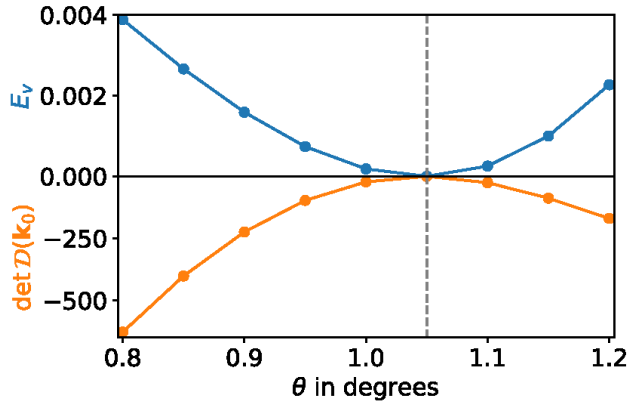


Dirac cone at $\omega = 0$: $\rho \sim |\omega|$

van Hove peaks at $\pm E_v$

1.05°: the peaks merge





higher-order saddle $\quad E = \alpha p_x^2 + \gamma p_x p_y^2 + \kappa p_y^4 \implies \rho(E) \sim |E|^{-1/4}$

Yuan, Isobe, Fu, Nat. Commun. 10, 5769 (2019)

At 1.05° the two vHs merge into a higher-order vHs

A van Hove peak boosts T_K

	Density of states $\rho(\omega)$	T_K	$S_{\rm imp}(T \to 0)$
Metal	ρ_0 : constant	$D\, e^{-1/\rho_0 J}$	0
Dirac cone	$\rho_0 \lvert\omega\rvert$: linear pseudogap	$T_K = 0$	$\ln 2$
Standard van Hove	$\rho_0 \left[1 + a \ln(D/\lvert\omega\rvert)\right]$: log divergence	$D\, e^{\frac{1}{a} - \frac{1}{a}\sqrt{1+\frac{2a}{\rho_0 J}}}$	0
Higher-order van Hove	$\rho_0 \lvert\omega\rvert^{-\alpha}$: power-law divergence	$D \left(1 + \frac{\alpha D^\alpha}{\rho_0 J}\right)^{-1/\alpha}$	$-2\alpha \ln 2$

Mitchell, Vojta, Bulla, Fritz, PRB 88, 195119 (2013)

A van Hove peak boosts T_K

	Density of states $\rho(\omega)$	T_K	$S_{\rm imp}(T \to 0)$
Metal	ρ_0 : constant	$D\, e^{-1/\rho_0 J}$	0
Dirac cone	$\rho_0 \lvert\omega\rvert$: linear pseudogap	$T_K = 0$	$\ln 2$
Standard van Hove	$\rho_0 \left[1 + a \ln(D/\lvert\omega\rvert)\right]$: log divergence	$D\, e^{\frac{1}{a} - \frac{1}{a}\sqrt{1+\frac{2a}{\rho_0 J}}}$	0
Higher-order van Hove	$\rho_0 \lvert\omega\rvert^{-\alpha}$: power-law divergence	$D \left(1 + \frac{\alpha D^\alpha}{\rho_0 J}\right)^{-1/\alpha}$	$-2\alpha \ln 2$

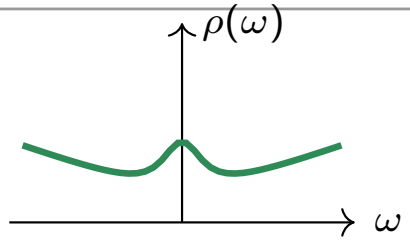
Mitchell, Vojta, Bulla, Fritz, PRB 88, 195119 (2013)

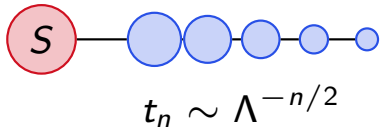
Logarithmic vHs: T_K enhanced over the metal

Higher-order vHs: T_K grows as a power law in J

In TBG the cone and the vHs sit within a few meV of each other: which one wins?

NRG settles it non-perturbatively: read the answer off the impurity entropy

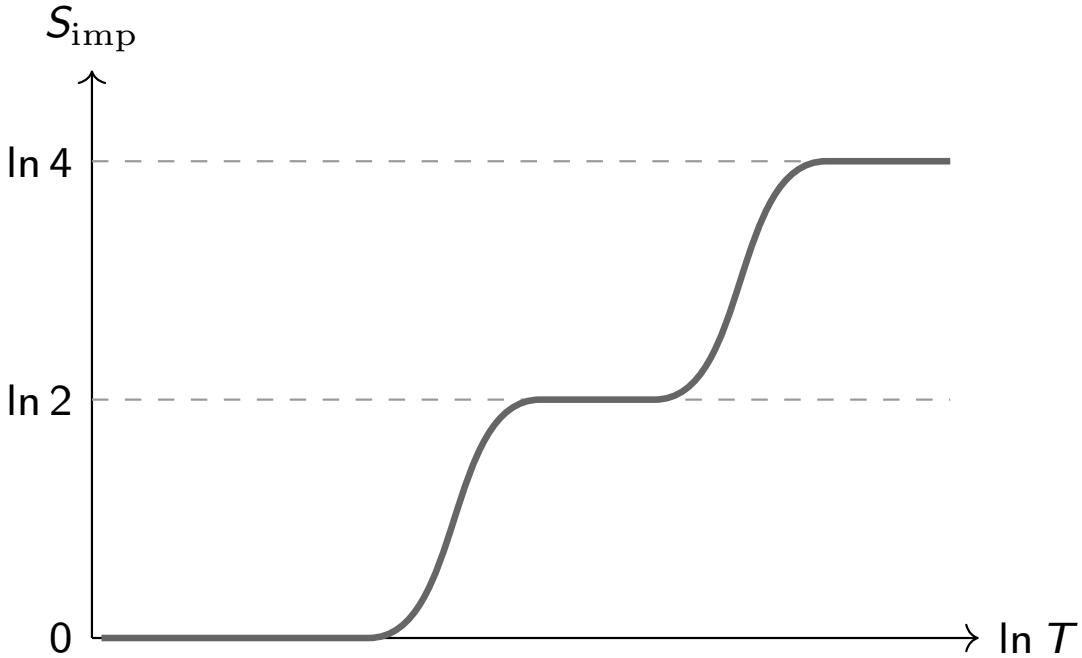




3. $S_{\rm imp}(T)$

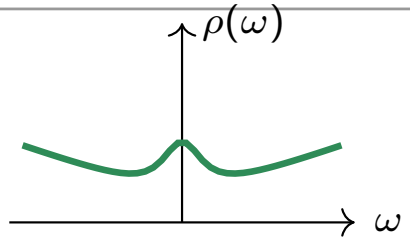
1. host DoS $\rho(\omega)$

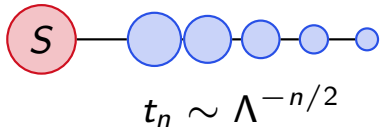
2. Wilson chain, solved iteratively



A plateau at ln **N**: **N states** available to the impurity

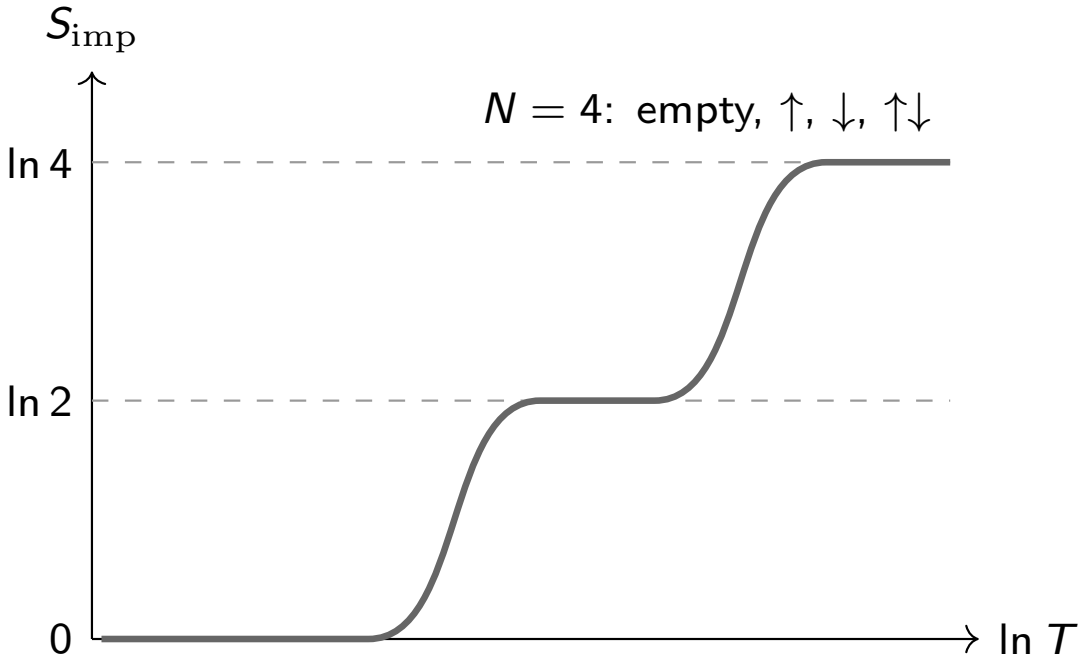
NRG settles it non-perturbatively: read the answer off the impurity entropy





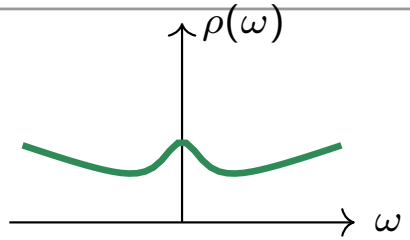
3. $S_{\rm imp}(T)$

1. host DoS $\rho(\omega)$ **2.** Wilson chain, solved iteratively

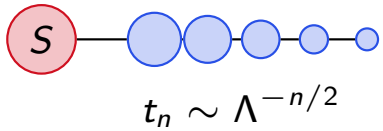


A plateau at ln **N**: **N states** available to the impurity

NRG settles it non-perturbatively: read the answer off the impurity entropy

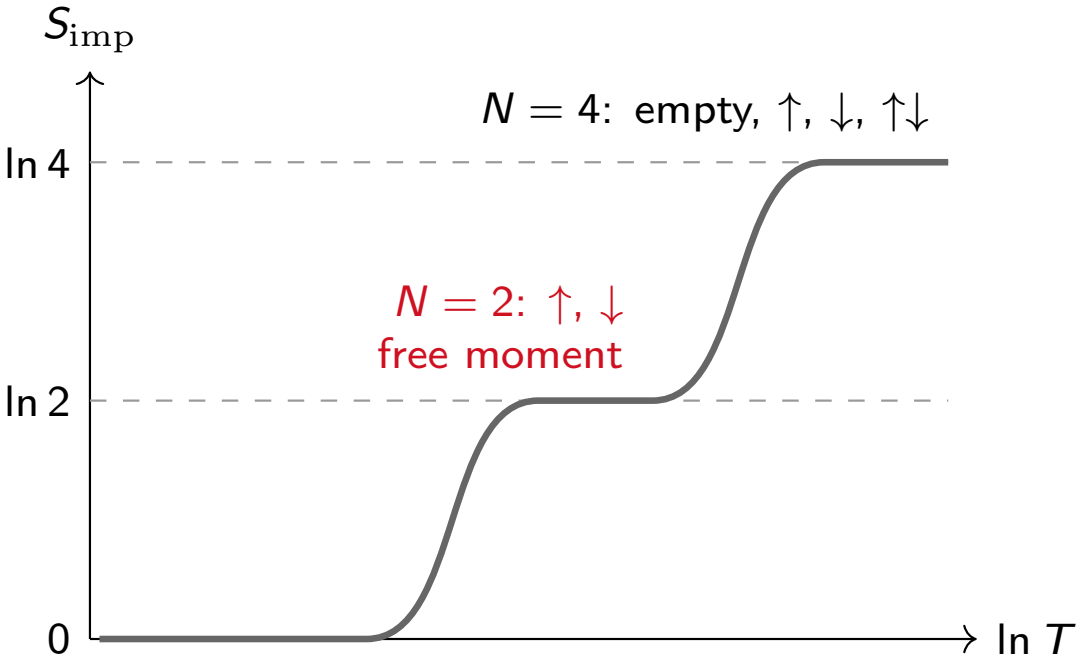


1. host DoS $\rho(\omega)$



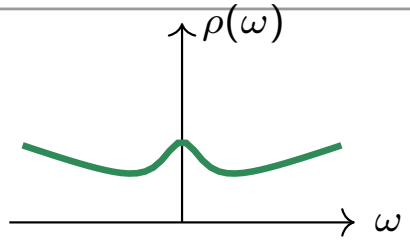
2. Wilson chain, solved iteratively

3. $S_{\rm imp}(T)$

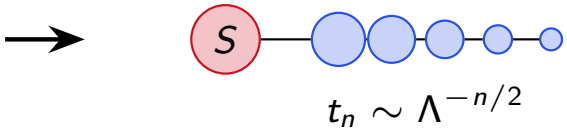


A plateau at ln **N**: **N states** available to the impurity

NRG settles it non-perturbatively: read the answer off the impurity entropy

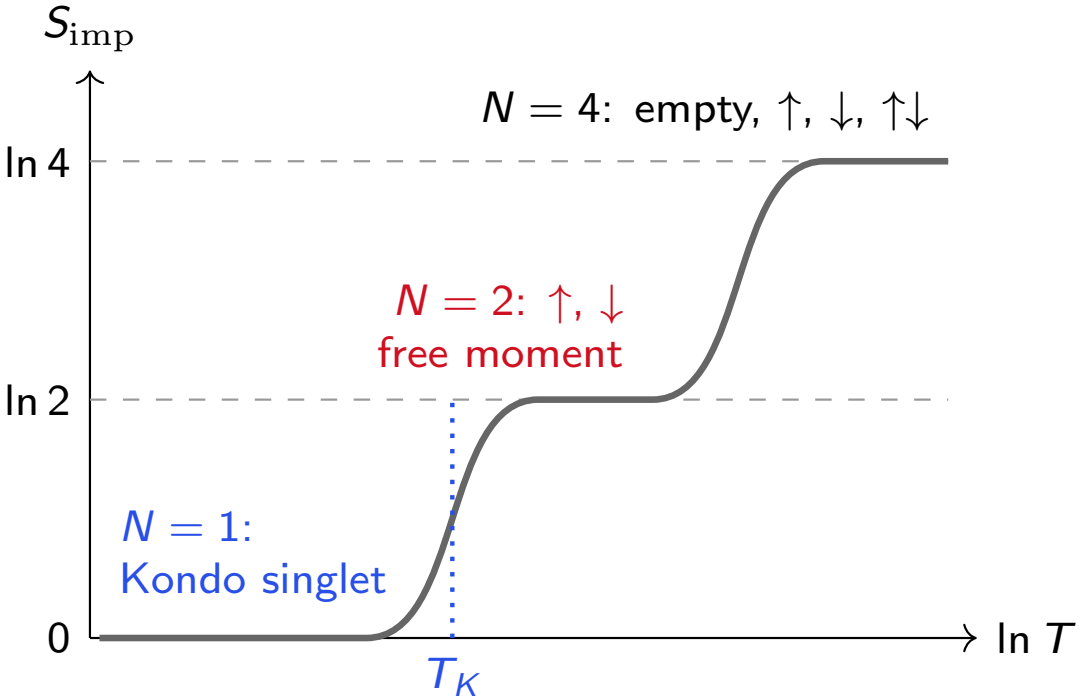


1. host DoS $\rho(\omega)$



2. Wilson chain, solved iteratively

3. $S_{\mathrm{imp}}(T)$



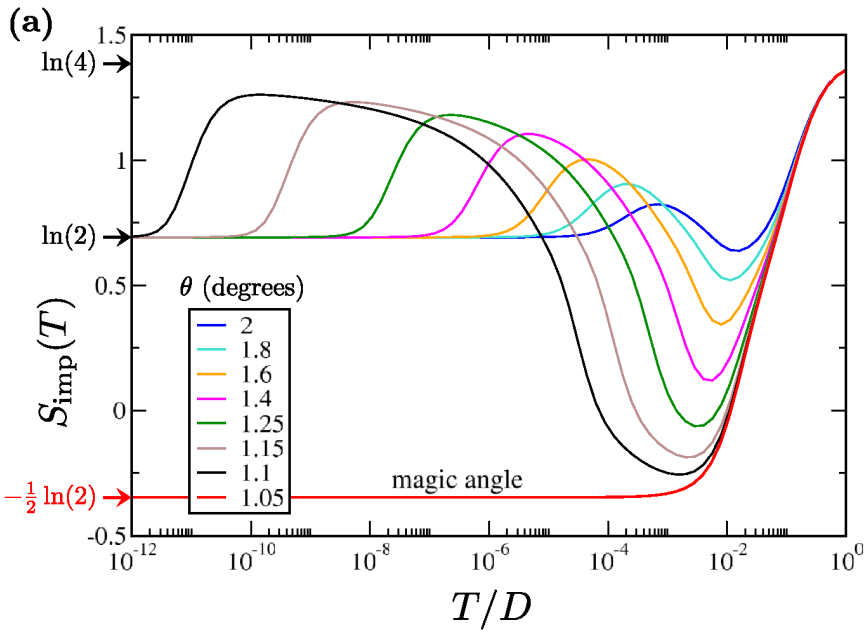
A plateau at ln **N**: **N states** available to the impurity

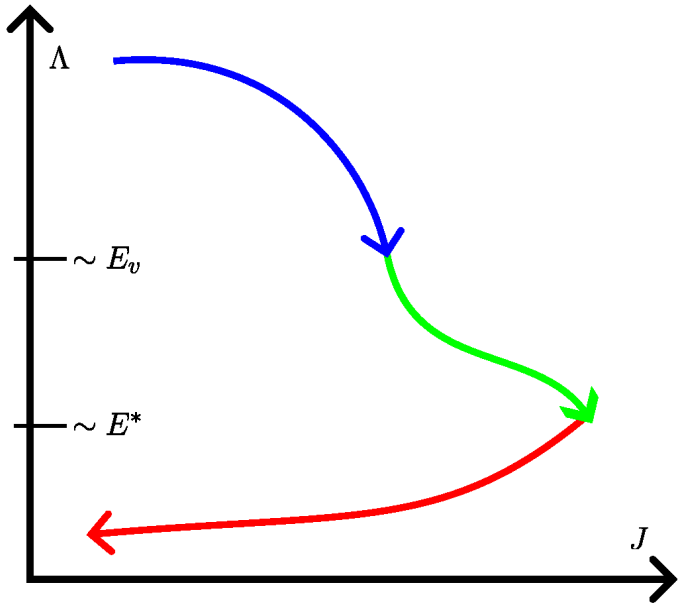
A step between plateaus: a screening scale, here T_K

$S_{\mathrm{imp}} = S_{\mathrm{total}} - S_{\mathrm{host}}$, so it can be negative

This curve is the one diagnostic used for the rest of the talk

Kondo revival at the magic angle



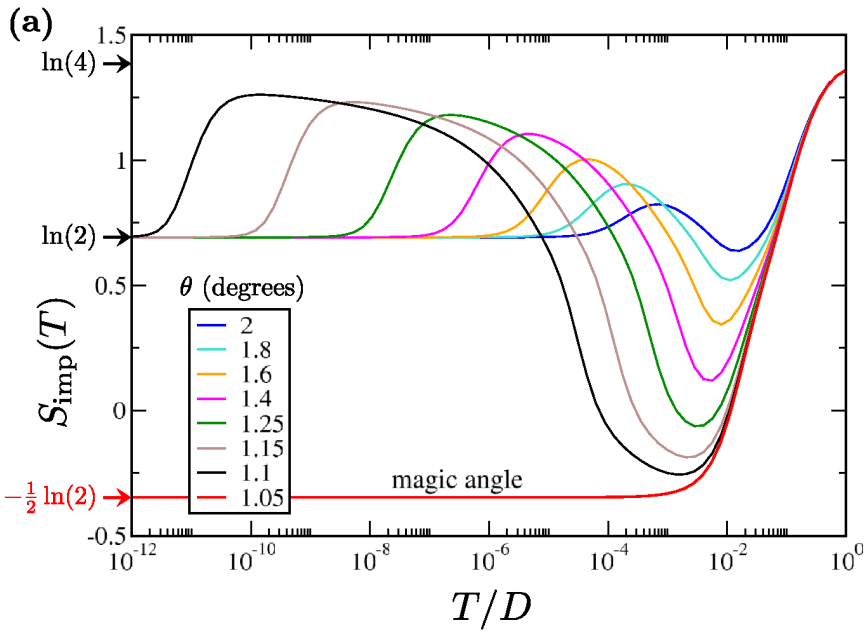


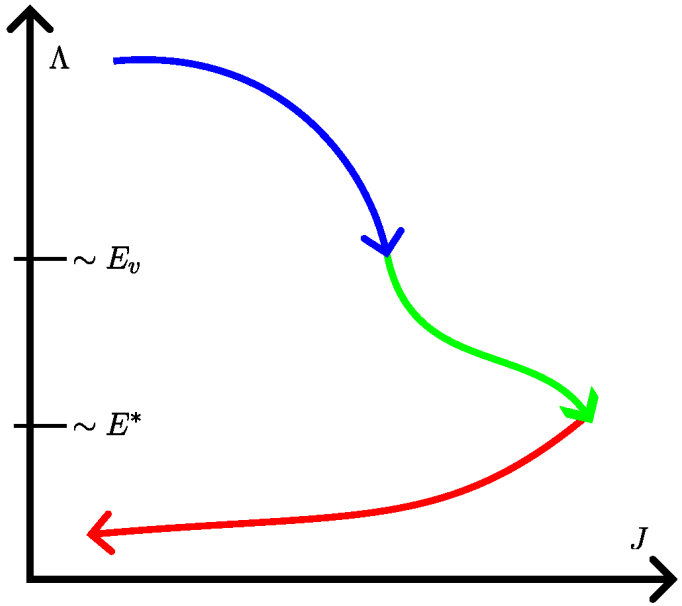
Shankar, Oriekhov, Mitchell, Fritz, PRB 107, 245102 (2023)

See also: Chang, Yi, Wu, Kugler, Andrei, Vanderbilt, Kotliar, Pixley, PRL 133, 126503 (2024)

Screening begins at E_v; below $E^* \sim |E_v|^3$ the cone wins: moment unscreened

Kondo revival at the magic angle





Shankar, Oriekhov, Mitchell, Fritz, PRB 107, 245102 (2023)

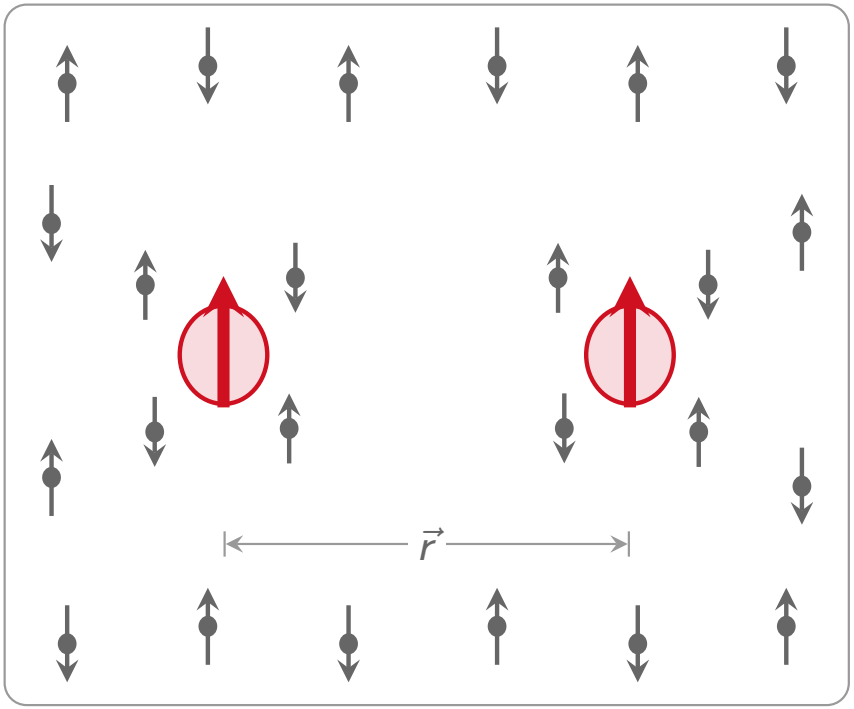
See also: Chang, Yi, Wu, Kugler, Andrei, Vanderbilt, Kotliar, Pixley, PRL 133, 126503 (2024)

Screening begins at E_v; below $E^* \sim |E_v|^3$ the cone wins: moment unscreened

Magic angle: E_v, $E^* \to 0$, the cone never wins: moment screened

One impurity is only the dilute limit. What happens when two sit close together?

Two impurities: the RKKY interaction

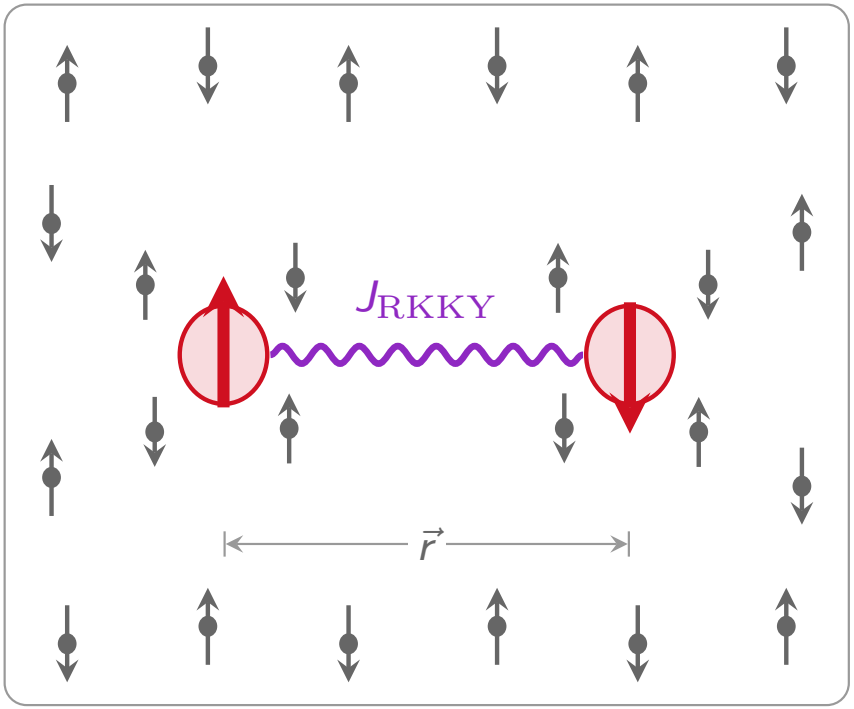


two local moments

$$H = H_{\text{host}} + J \sum_{i=1,2} \vec{S}_i \cdot \vec{s}(\vec{r}_i)$$

Each spin couples to the electrons at its own site

Two impurities: the RKKY interaction



the moments lock together

Jayaprakash, Krishna-murthy, Wilkins, PRL 47, 737 (1981)
Jones, Varma, Wilkins, PRL 61, 125 (1988)
STM experiment: Spinelli et al., Nat. Commun. 6, 10046 (2015)

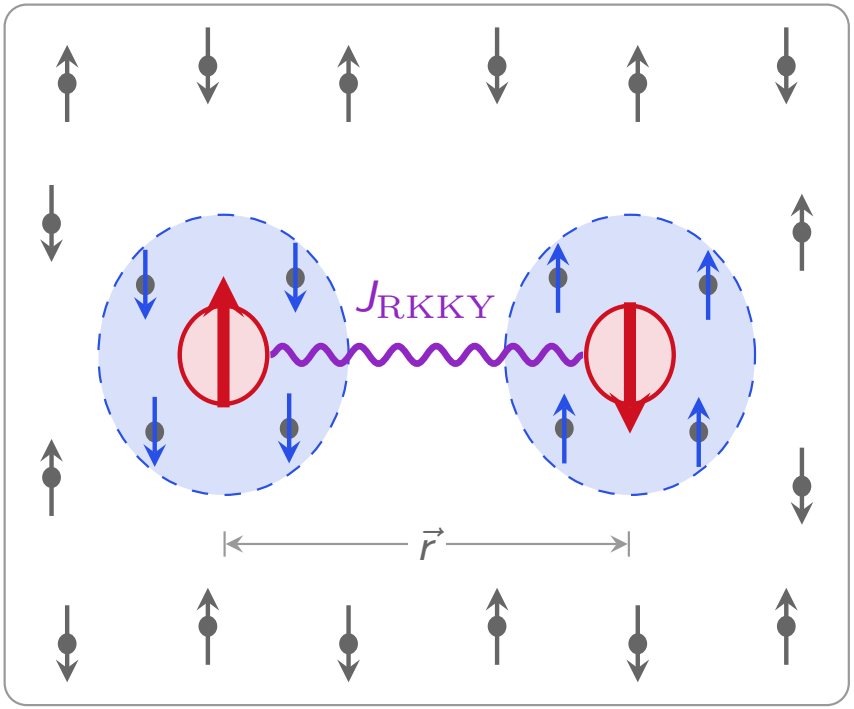
$$H = H_{\mathrm{host}} + J \sum_{i=1,2} \vec{S}_i \cdot \vec{s}(\vec{r}_i)$$

Each spin couples to the electrons at its own site

The electrons carry an effective exchange $J_{\mathrm{RKKY}}\, \vec{S}_1 \cdot \vec{S}_2$

$$J_{\mathrm{RKKY}} \simeq 2J^2 \int_{\Omega_1 < E_F < \Omega_2} \frac{d\Omega_1 d\Omega_2}{\pi^2} \frac{\rho(-\vec{r}, \Omega_1)\, \rho(\vec{r}, \Omega_2)}{\Omega_1 - \Omega_2}$$

Two impurities: the RKKY interaction



or each one Kondo-screened?

Jayaprakash, Krishna-murthy, Wilkins, PRL 47, 737 (1981)
Jones, Varma, Wilkins, PRL 61, 125 (1988)
STM experiment: Spinelli et al., Nat. Commun. 6, 10046 (2015)

$$H = H_{\mathrm{host}} + J \sum_{i=1,2} \vec{S}_i \cdot \vec{s}(\vec{r}_i)$$

Each spin couples to the electrons at its own site

The electrons carry an effective exchange $J_{\mathrm{RKKY}}\, \vec{S}_1 \cdot \vec{S}_2$

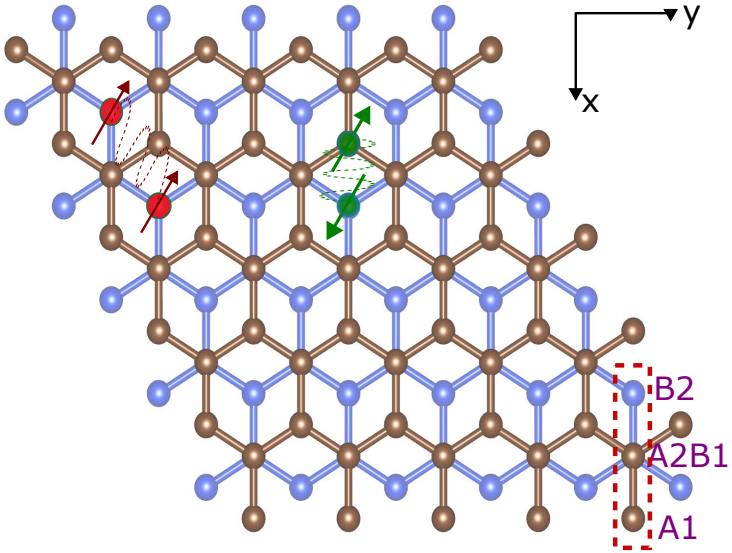
$$J_{\mathrm{RKKY}} \simeq 2J^2 \int_{\Omega_1 < E_F < \Omega_2} \frac{d\Omega_1 d\Omega_2}{\pi^2} \frac{\rho(-\vec{r}, \Omega_1)\, \rho(\vec{r}, \Omega_2)}{\Omega_1 - \Omega_2}$$

Needed: $\rho(\vec{r}, \omega) = -\,\mathrm{Im}\, G(\vec{r}, \omega)$

non-local Green's function between the two sites, at all energies

RKKY $\propto J^2$, Kondo $\sim e^{-1/\rho_0 J}$: which one wins?

Bernal bilayer graphene, no twist



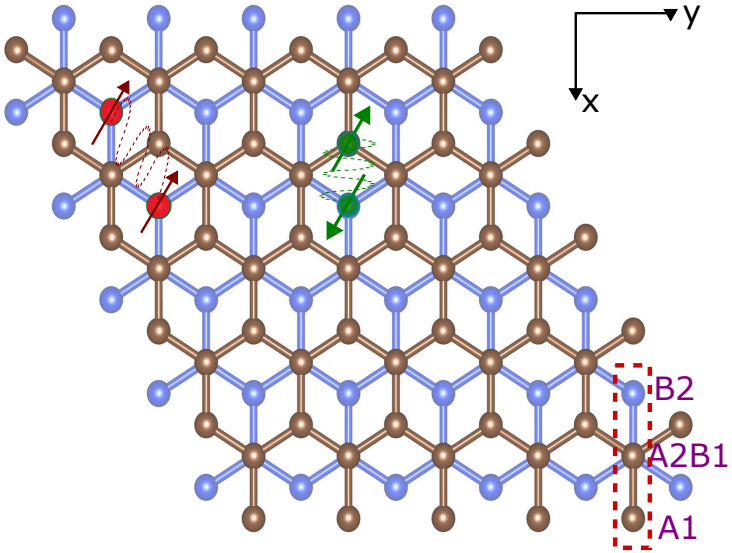
4-band tight binding, fitted to infrared spectra

parameter	value (eV)	what it does
γ_0	3.16	in-plane A–B hopping
γ_1	0.381	vertical B1–A2 (stacked sites)
γ_3	0.38	skew A1–B2: trigonal warping
γ_4	0.14	skew A1–A2, B1–B2: e–h asym.
Δ'	0.022	stacked-site energy: e–h asym.

Model: McCann, Koshino, Rep. Prog. Phys. 76, 056503 (2013)
Experiment: Kuzmenko et al., PRB 80, 165406 (2009)

RKKY in bilayer graphene:
Jiang et al., J. Phys.: Condens. Matter 24, 206003 (2012)
Parhizgar, Sherafati, Asgari, Satpathy, PRB 87, 165429 (2013)
Klier, Shallcross, Pankratov, PRB 90, 245118 (2014)

Bernal bilayer graphene, no twist

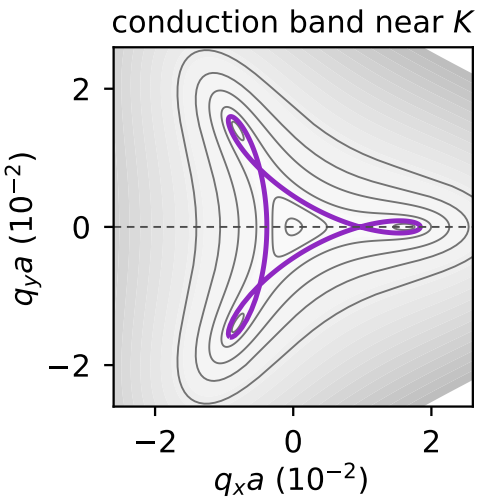


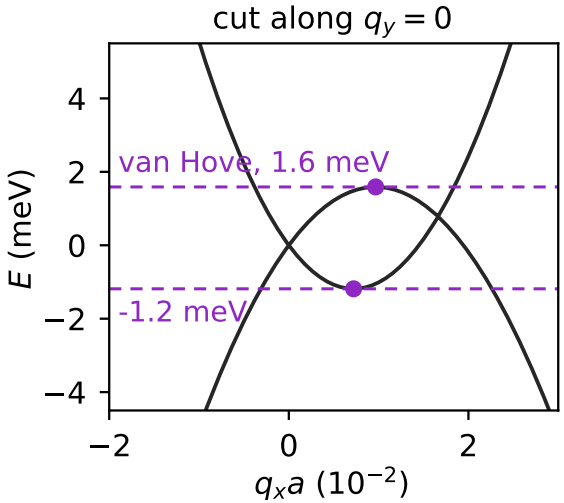
4-band tight binding, fitted to infrared spectra

parameter	value (eV)	what it does
γ_0	3.16	in-plane A–B hopping
γ_1	0.381	vertical B1–A2 (stacked sites)
γ_3	0.38	skew A1–B2: trigonal warping
γ_4	0.14	skew A1–A2, B1–B2: e–h asym.
Δ'	0.022	stacked-site energy: e–h asym.

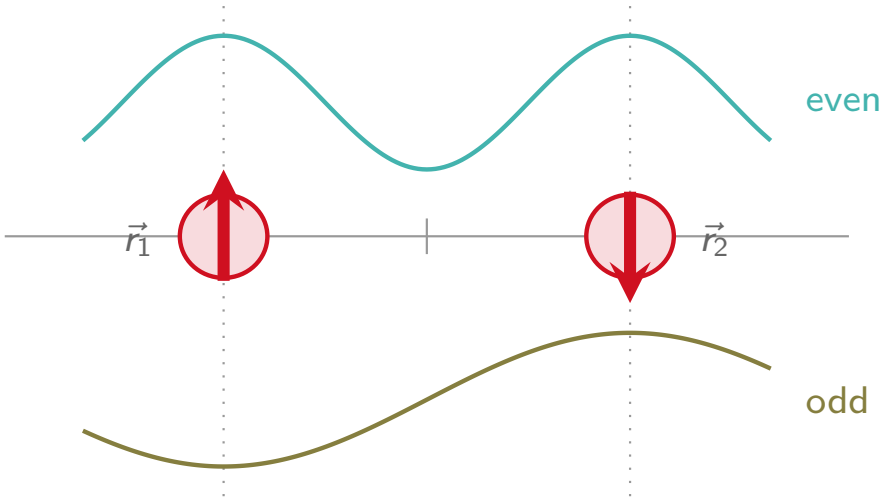
Model: McCann, Koshino, Rep. Prog. Phys. 76, 056503 (2013)
Experiment: Kuzmenko et al., PRB 80, 165406 (2009)

RKKY in bilayer graphene:
Jiang et al., J. Phys.: Condens. Matter 24, 206003 (2012)
Parhizgar, Sherafati, Asgari, Satpathy, PRB 87, 165429 (2013)
Klier, Shallcross, Pankratov, PRB 90, 245118 (2014)





NRG for two impurities: even and odd channels



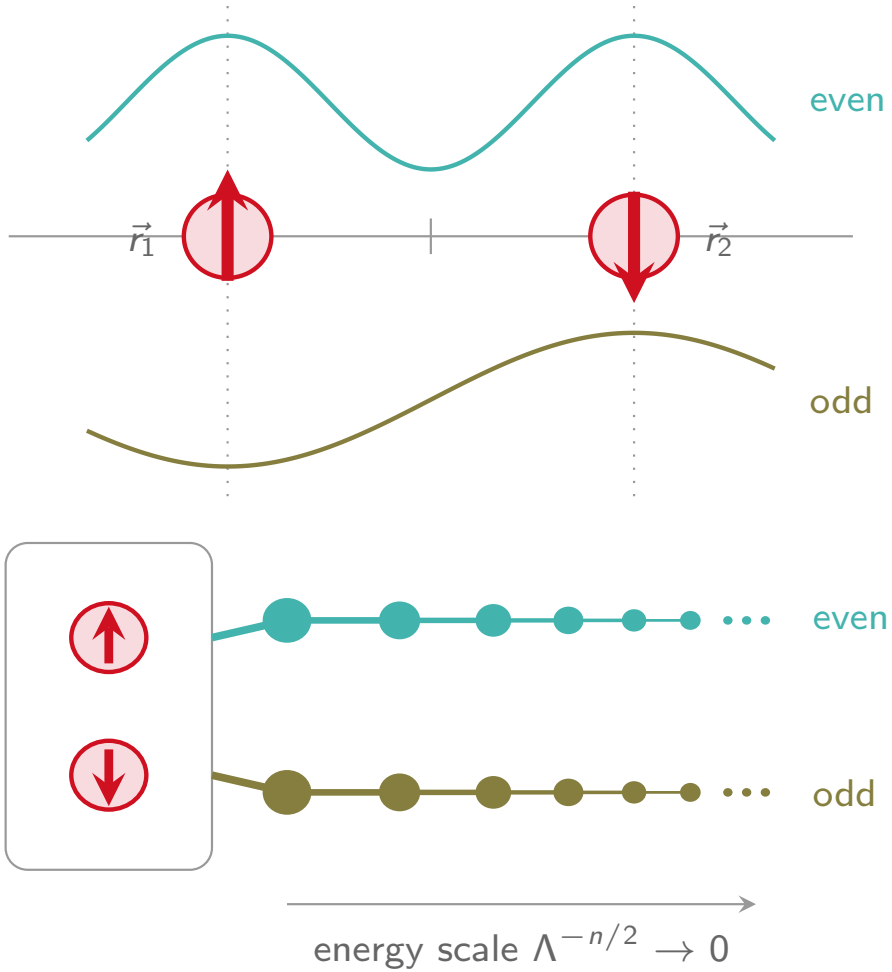
Sort the host electrons by parity about the midpoint

even: $\psi_{\mathrm{e}} \propto \psi(\vec{r}_1) + \psi(\vec{r}_2)$

odd: $\psi_{\mathrm{o}} \propto \psi(\vec{r}_1) - \psi(\vec{r}_2)$

$\psi(\vec{r}_i)$: host electron at impurity site i

NRG for two impurities: even and odd channels



Sort the host electrons by parity about the midpoint

even: $\psi_{\rm e} \propto \psi(\vec{r}_1) + \psi(\vec{r}_2)$

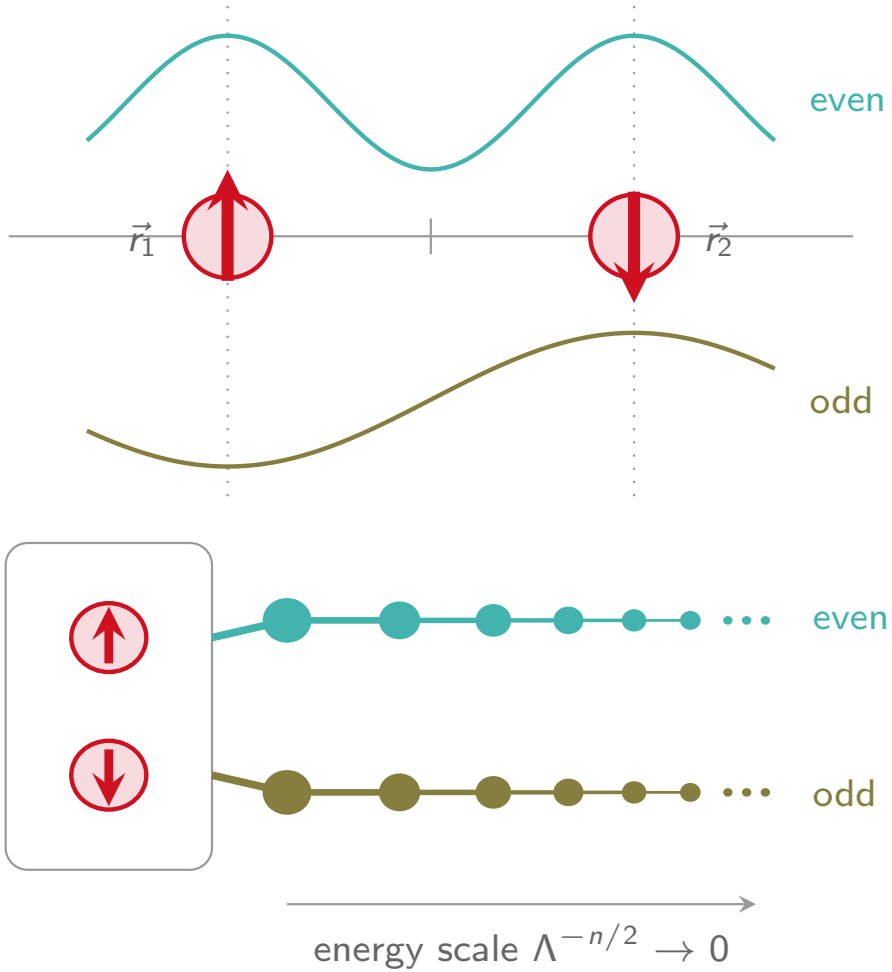
odd: $\psi_{\rm o} \propto \psi(\vec{r}_1) - \psi(\vec{r}_2)$

$\psi(\vec{r}_i)$: host electron at impurity site i

Each channel: one Wilson chain. NRG treats both spins at once

Jayaprakash, Krishna-murthy, Wilkins, PRL 47, 737 (1981)
Jones, Varma, Wilkins, PRL 61, 125 (1988)
Affleck, Ludwig, PRL 68, 1046 (1992)
Affleck, Ludwig, Jones, PRB 52, 9528 (1995)

NRG for two impurities: even and odd channels



Sort the host electrons by parity about the midpoint

even: $\psi_{\rm e} \propto \psi(\vec{r}_1) + \psi(\vec{r}_2)$

odd: $\psi_{\rm o} \propto \psi(\vec{r}_1) - \psi(\vec{r}_2)$

$\psi(\vec{r}_i)$: host electron at impurity site i

Each channel: one Wilson chain. NRG treats both spins at once

$$\rho_{\rm e/o}(\omega) = \rho(0,\omega) \pm \rho(\vec{r},\omega)$$

local $\pm$ non-local density of states: the only input from the host

Jayaprakash, Krishna-murthy, Wilkins, PRL 47, 737 (1981)
Jones, Varma, Wilkins, PRL 61, 125 (1988)
Affleck, Ludwig, PRL 68, 1046 (1992)
Affleck, Ludwig, Jones, PRB 52, 9528 (1995)

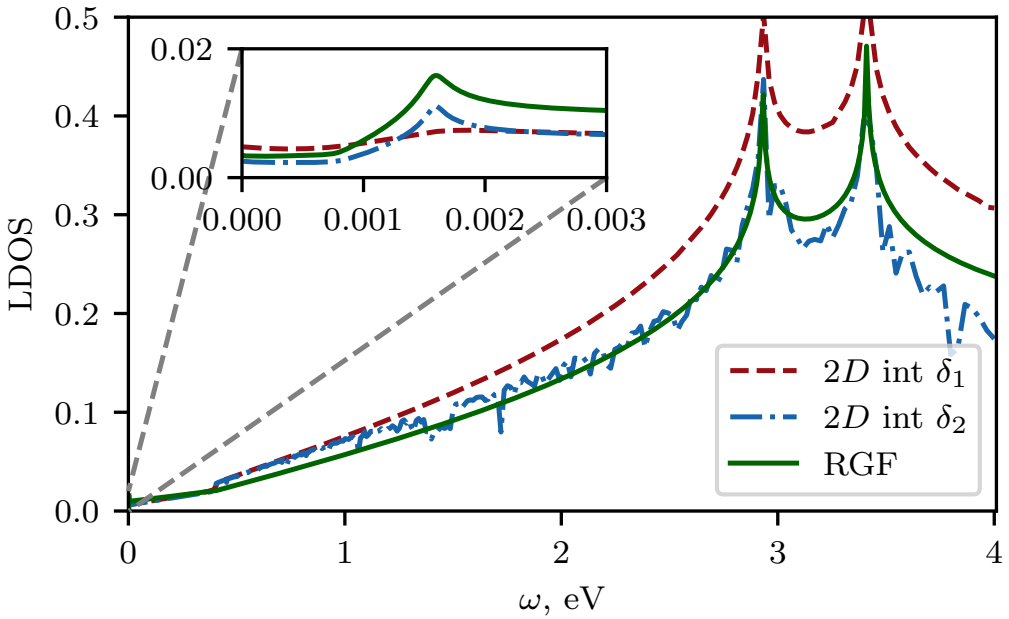
The low-energy local and non-local DoS must be well resolved

The DoS on every energy scale

$$G(\vec{k},\omega) = \left[\omega + i\delta - H(\vec{k})\right]^{-1} \xrightarrow{\text{the impurity is local}} G(\vec{r},\omega) = \int_{\mathrm{BZ}} \frac{d^2k}{(2\pi)^2}\, e^{i\vec{k}\cdot\vec{r}}\, G(\vec{k},\omega)$$

momentum space: immediate from $H(\vec{k})$

real space: a 2D integral at every energy



LDoS on an unstacked site (A1/B2). $\delta_{1,2}$: two broadenings of the 2D integral

NRG logarithmic energy grid, down to far below 1 meV

van Hove peak: $\sim 10^{-4}$ of the Brillouin zone

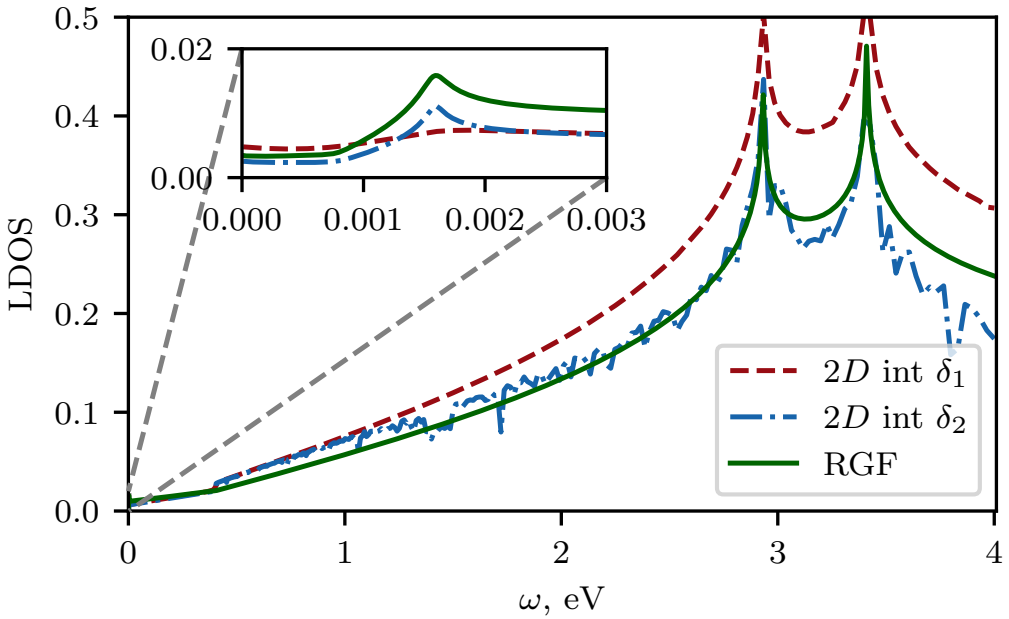
RGF recursive Green's functions: smooth, peak resolved

The DoS on every energy scale

$$G(\vec{k},\omega) = \left[\omega + i\delta - H(\vec{k})\right]^{-1} \xrightarrow{\text{the impurity is local}} G(\vec{r},\omega) = \int_{\mathrm{BZ}} \frac{d^2k}{(2\pi)^2}\, e^{i\vec{k}\cdot\vec{r}}\, G(\vec{k},\omega)$$

momentum space: immediate from $H(\vec{k})$

real space: a 2D integral at every energy



LDoS on an unstacked site (A1/B2). $\delta_{1,2}$: two broadenings of the 2D integral

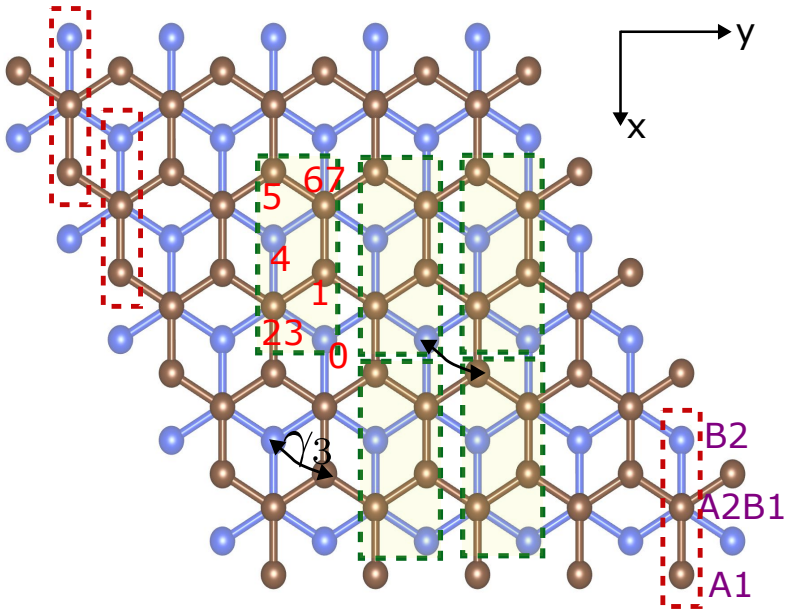
NRG logarithmic energy grid, down to far below 1 meV

van Hove peak: $\sim 10^{-4}$ of the Brillouin zone

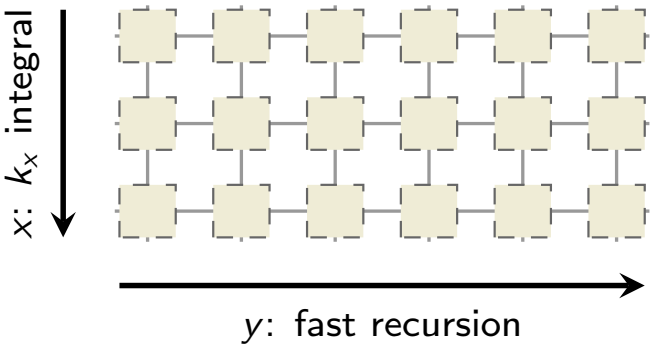
RGF recursive Green's functions: smooth, peak resolved

Direct integration is noisy: unsuitable for the logarithmic grid of NRG

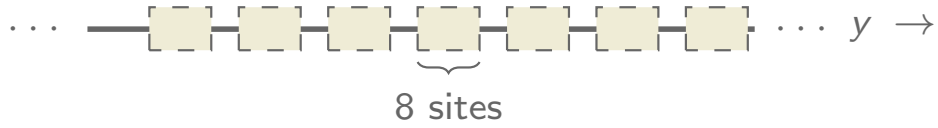
Fast recursive Green's functions



Bilayer graphene redrawn as a square lattice of 8-site cells



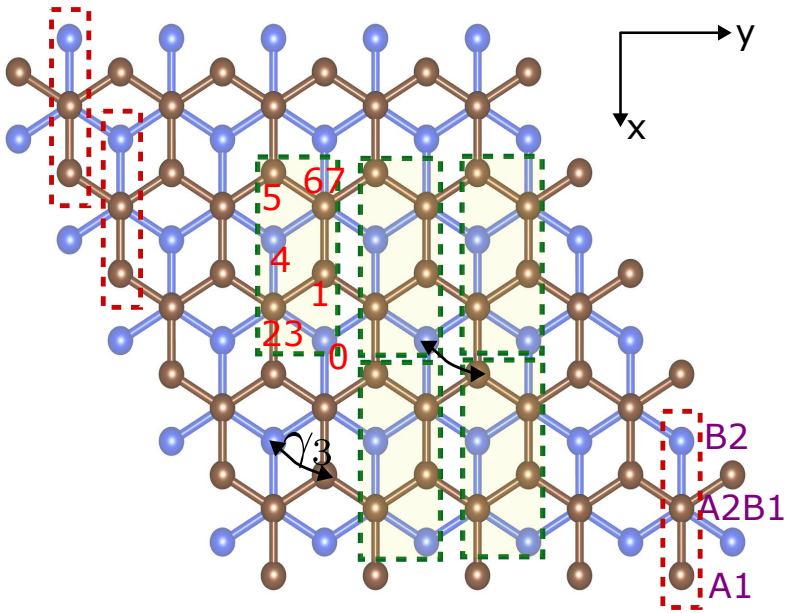
1. Fourier transform along x:
   for each k_x, a 1D chain of cells along y



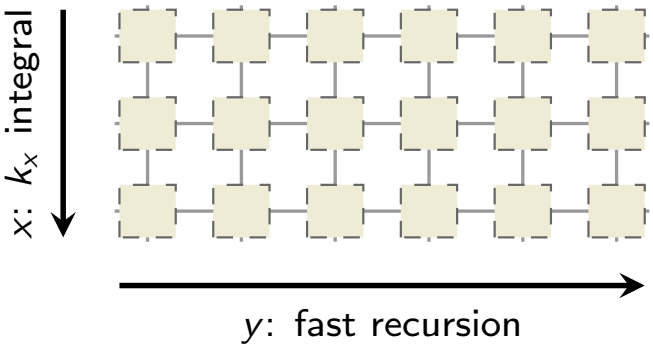
Cuba (Cuhre): Hahn, Comput. Phys. Commun. 168, 78 (2005)
Python interface: Buchner, github.com/JohannesBuchner/cuba

López Sancho, López Sancho, Rubio, J. Phys. F: Met. Phys. 14, 1205 (1984)
Lewenkopf, Mucciolo, J. Comput. Electron. 12, 203 (2013)

Fast recursive Green's functions

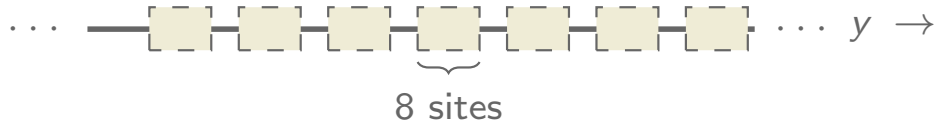


Bilayer graphene redrawn as a square lattice of 8-site cells

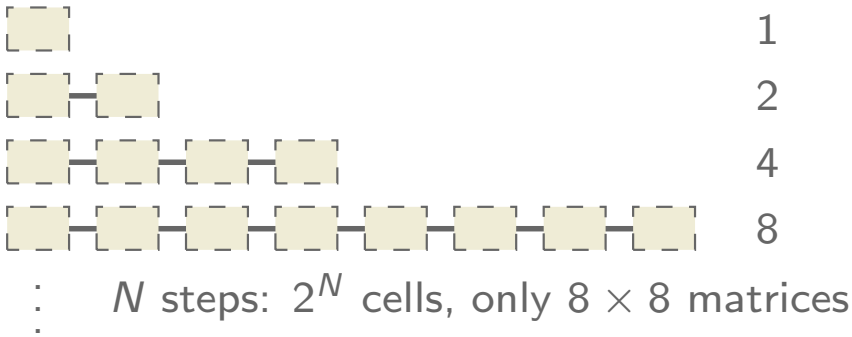


Cuba (Cuhre): Hahn, Comput. Phys. Commun. 168, 78 (2005)
Python interface: Buchner, github.com/JohannesBuchner/cuba

1. Fourier transform along x:
   for each k_x, a 1D chain of cells along y

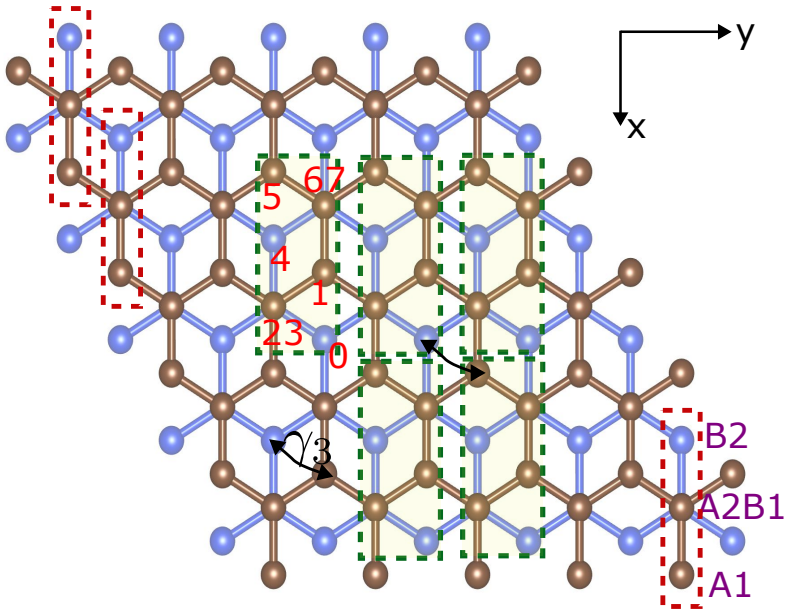


2. Recursion: each step doubles the chain

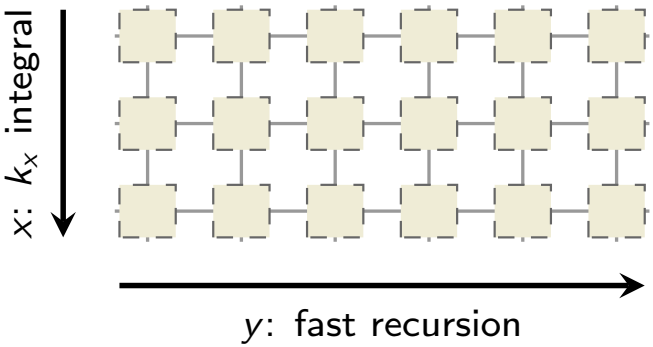


López Sancho, López Sancho, Rubio, J. Phys. F: Met. Phys. 14, 1205 (1984)
Lewenkopf, Mucciolo, J. Comput. Electron. 12, 203 (2013)

Fast recursive Green's functions

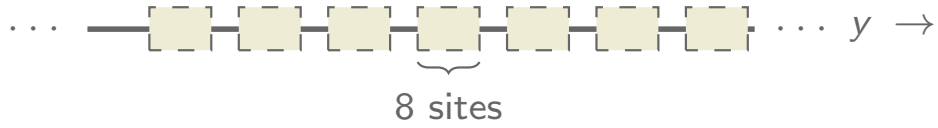


Bilayer graphene redrawn as a square lattice of 8-site cells

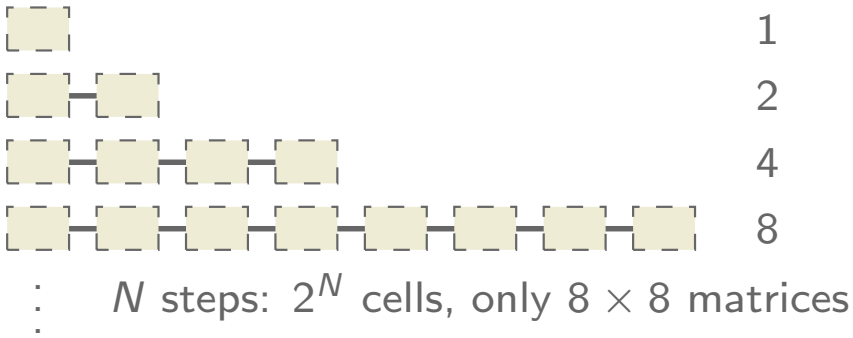


Cuba (Cuhre): Hahn, Comput. Phys. Commun. 168, 78 (2005)
Python interface: Buchner, github.com/JohannesBuchner/cuba

1. Fourier transform along x:
   for each k_x, a 1D chain of cells along y



2. Recursion: each step doubles the chain



N steps: 2^N cells, only 8×8 matrices

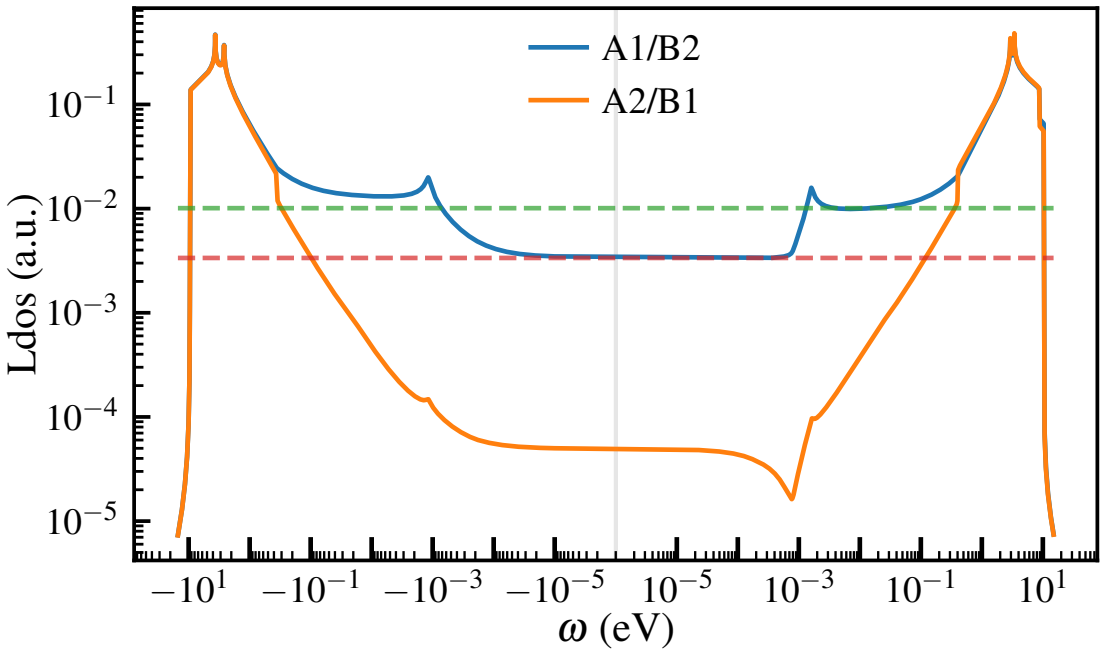
3. Adaptive integral over k_x (Cuhre):

$$G(\vec{r},\omega) = \int \frac{dk_x}{2\pi}\, e^{ik_x x}\, G_{\text{chain}}(k_x,\omega)$$

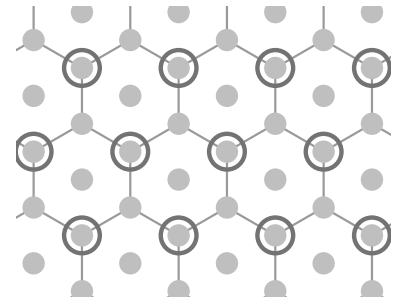
$$\Rightarrow \quad \rho(0,\omega),\ \ \rho(\vec{r},\omega)$$

López Sancho, López Sancho, Rubio, J. Phys. F: Met. Phys. 14, 1205 (1984)
Lewenkopf, Mucciolo, J. Comput. Electron. 12, 203 (2013)

Dilute limit: one impurity, two kinds of site



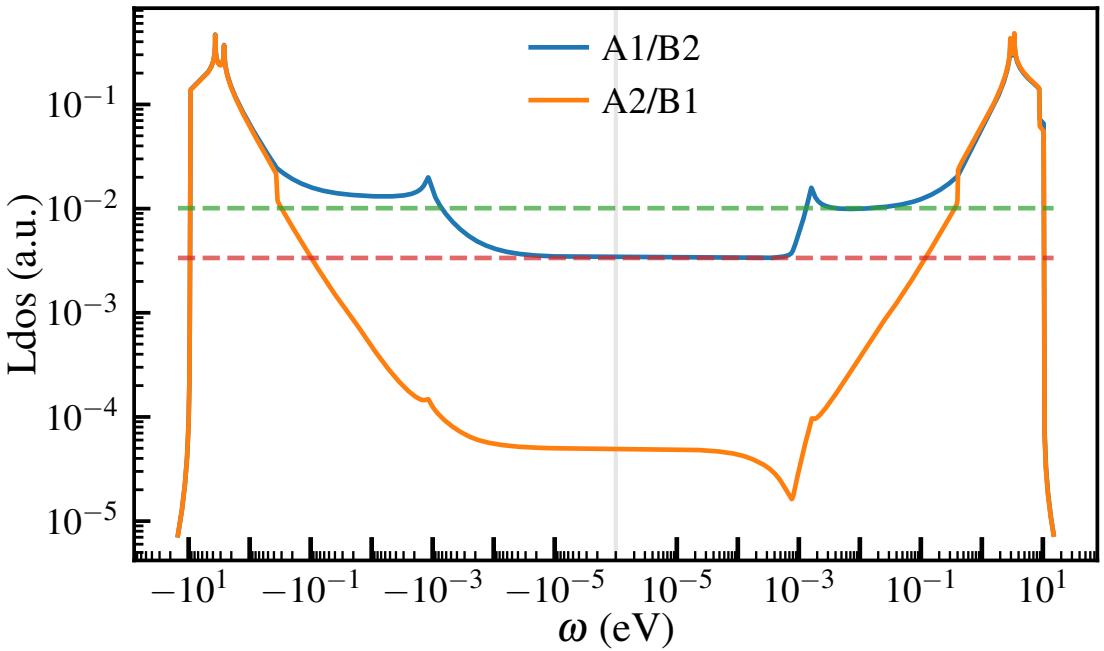
Local density of states from recursive Green's functions



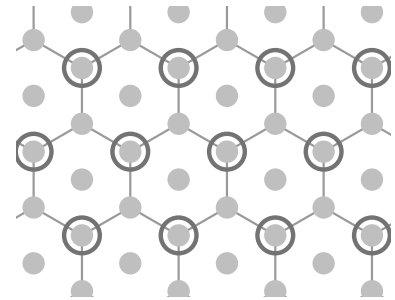
unstacked: A1, B2

stacked: A2/B1

Dilute limit: one impurity, two kinds of site



Local density of states from recursive Green's functions



Unstacked A1/B2

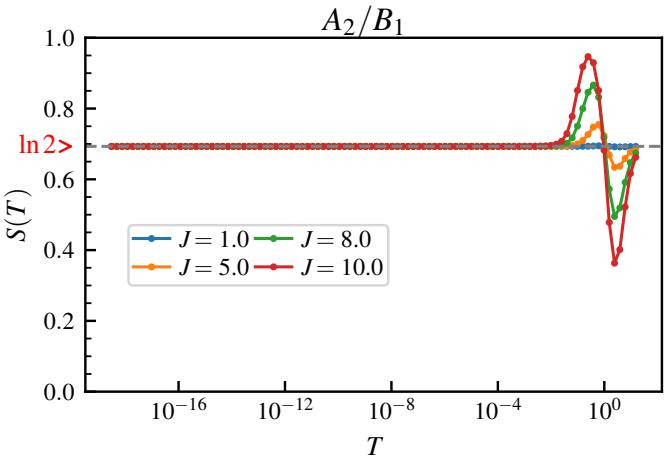
van Hove peak at 1.6 meV,
between two plateaus

Stacked A2/B1

100 times fewer states
at low energy

One impurity: Kondo only on unstacked sites

Stacked A2/B1

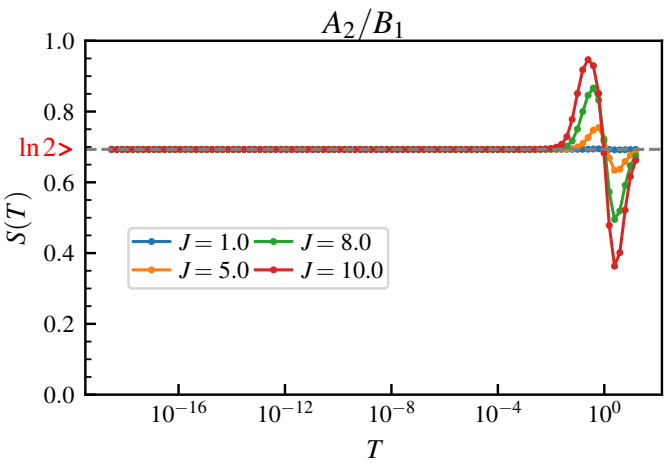


entropy stays at ln 2

free moment

One impurity: Kondo only on unstacked sites

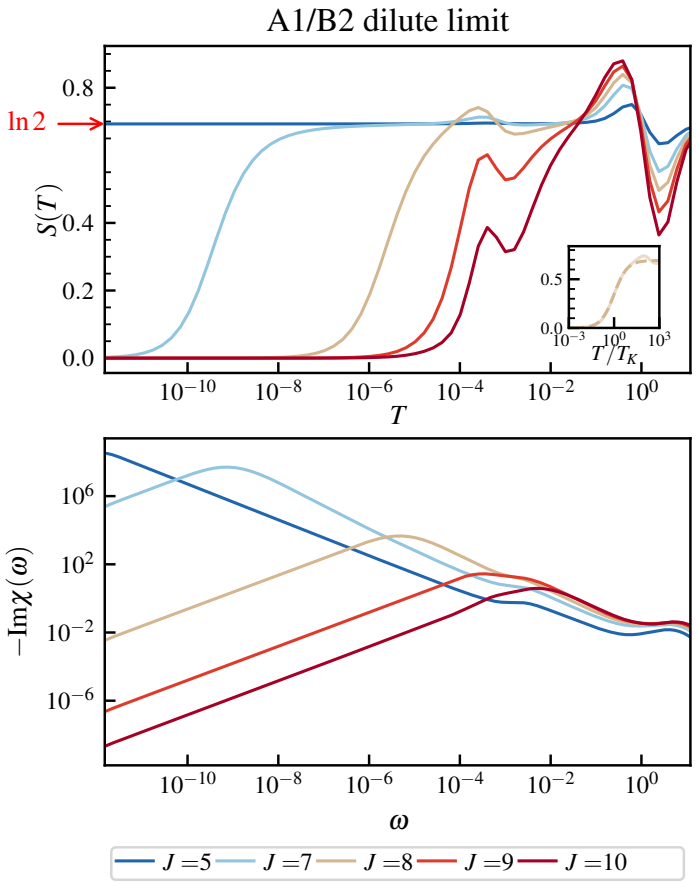
Stacked A2/B1



entropy stays at ln 2

free moment

Unstacked A1/B2



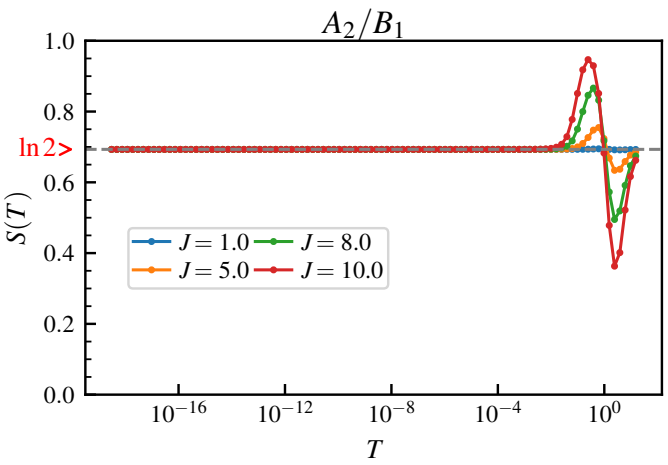
entropy $\ln 2 \to 0$

at strong coupling:

Kondo singlet

One impurity: Kondo only on unstacked sites

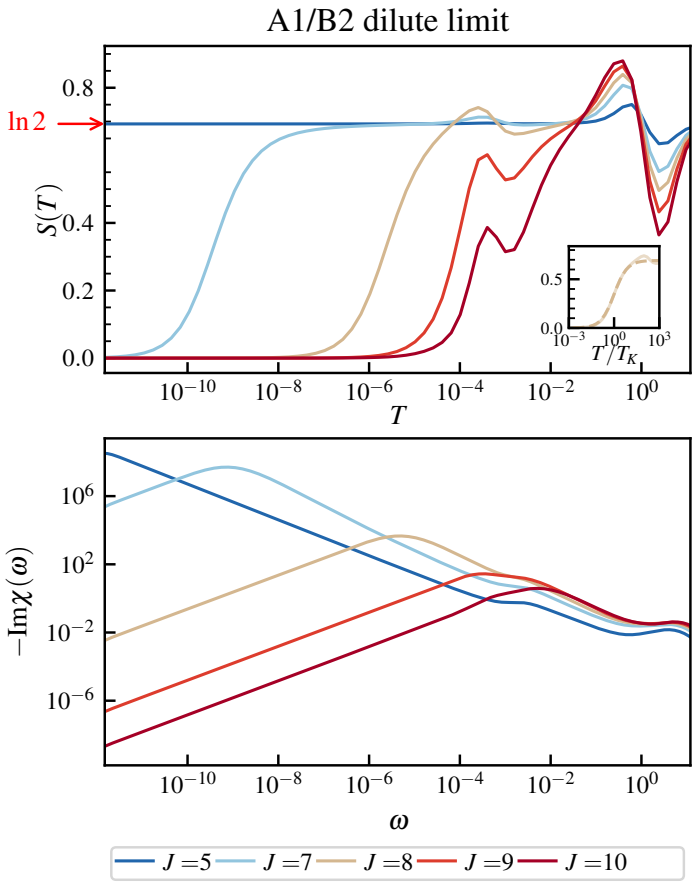
Stacked A2/B1



entropy stays at ln 2

free moment

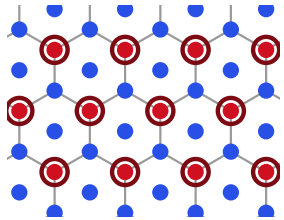
Unstacked A1/B2



entropy ln 2 → 0

at strong coupling:

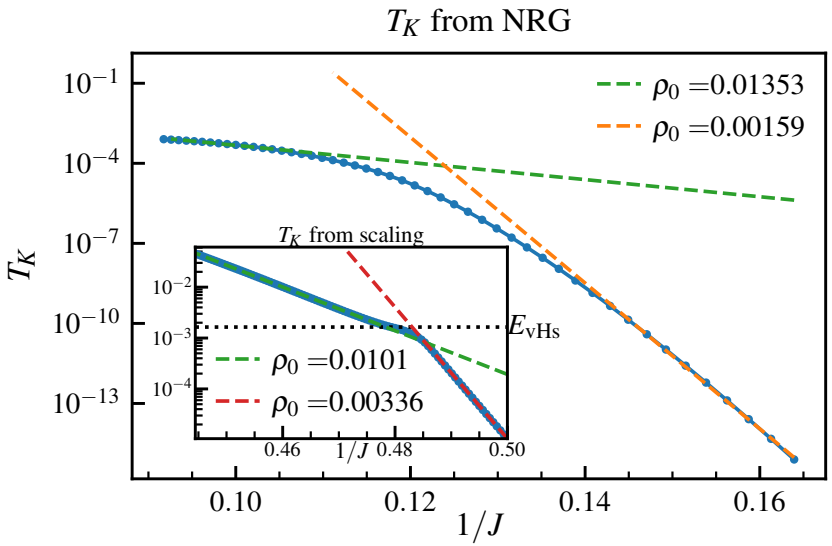
Kondo singlet



- free moment (A2/B1)
- Kondo (A1/B2)

Free moment or Kondo singlet: the site alone decides

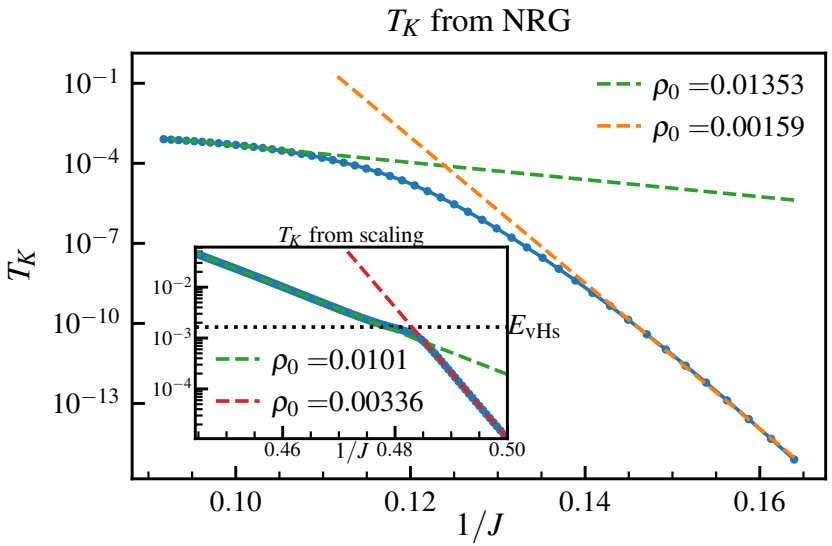
The Kondo scale follows two laws



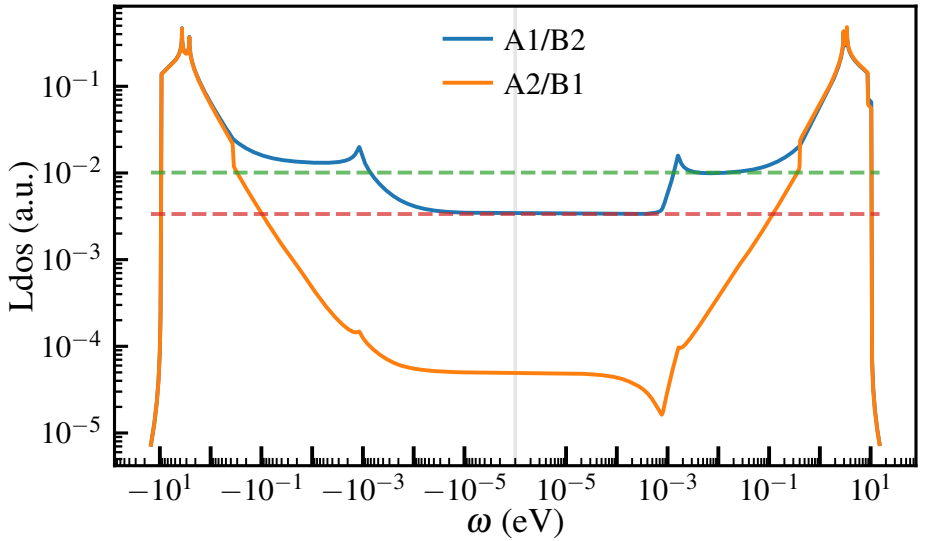
T_K on the unstacked site A1/B2, NRG
Inset: poor man's scaling, Anderson, J. Phys. C 3, 2436 (1970)

$$T_K \sim D\, e^{-1/\rho_{\mathrm{eff}} J}$$

The Kondo scale follows two laws



T_K on the unstacked site A1/B2, NRG
Inset: poor man's scaling, Anderson, J. Phys. C 3, 2436 (1970)



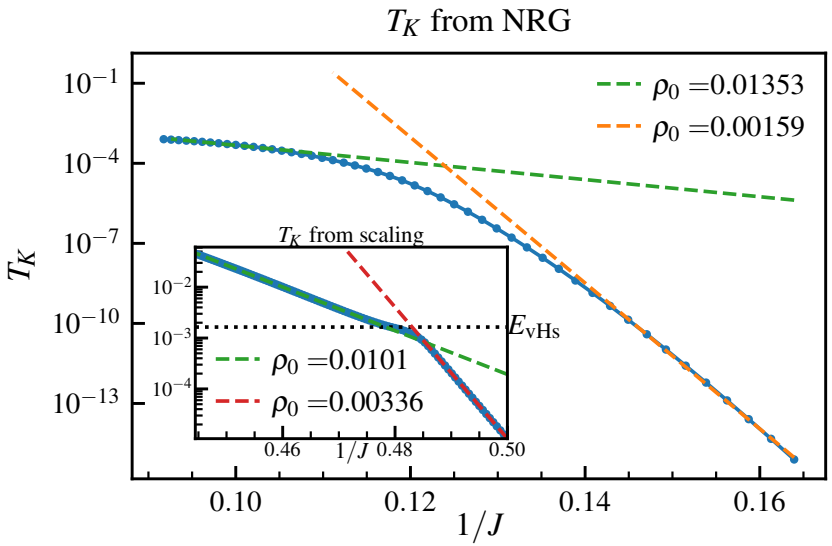
Local density of states
Dashed lines: the two plateaus of A1/B2

$$T_K \sim D\, e^{-1/\rho_{\mathrm{eff}} J}$$

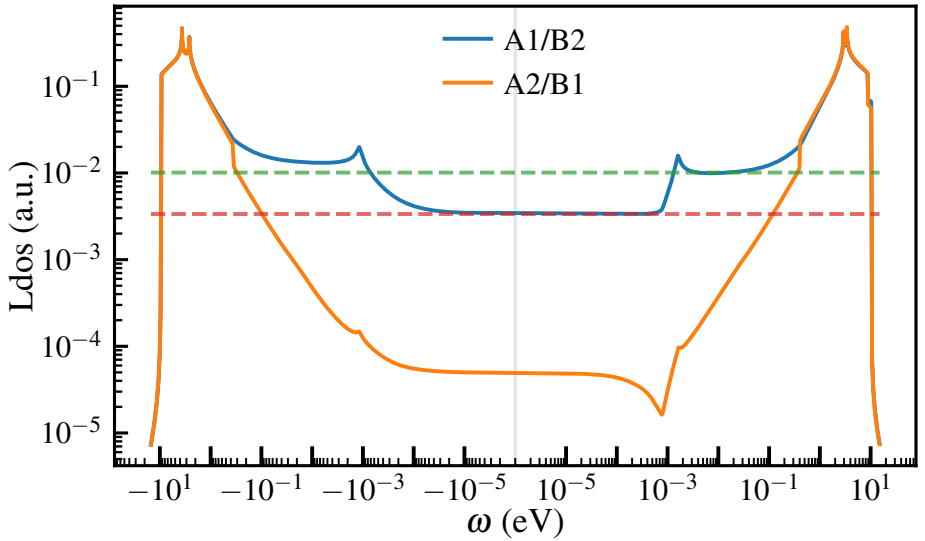
weak J: T_K below the van Hove peak, ρ_{eff} = low plateau

strong J: T_K above the van Hove peak, ρ_{eff} = high plateau

The Kondo scale follows two laws



T_K on the unstacked site A1/B2, NRG
Inset: poor man's scaling, Anderson, J. Phys. C 3, 2436 (1970)



Local density of states
Dashed lines: the two plateaus of A1/B2

$$T_K \sim D\, e^{-1/\rho_{\mathrm{eff}} J}$$

weak J: T_K below the van Hove peak, ρ_{eff} = low plateau

strong J: T_K above the van Hove peak, ρ_{eff} = high plateau

One site, two Kondo laws: the impurity reads out the van Hove singularity

Two impurities: the RKKY sign follows the sublattice

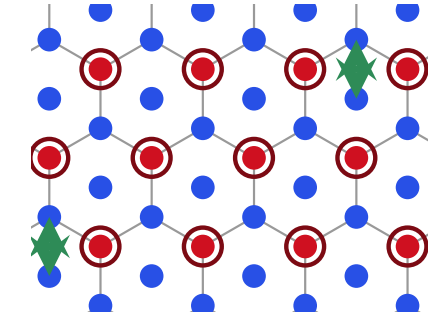
$$H = \sum_{\mathbf{k}} \epsilon_{\mathbf{k}} c_{\mathbf{k}}^{\dagger} c_{\mathbf{k}} + J \sum_{i=1,2} \mathbf{S}_i \cdot \boldsymbol{\sigma}(\mathbf{r}_i)$$

Same sublattice: **FM**

Opposite sublattice: **AFM**

$J_{\mathrm{RKKY}} \propto J^2$, $T_K \sim e^{-1/J}$

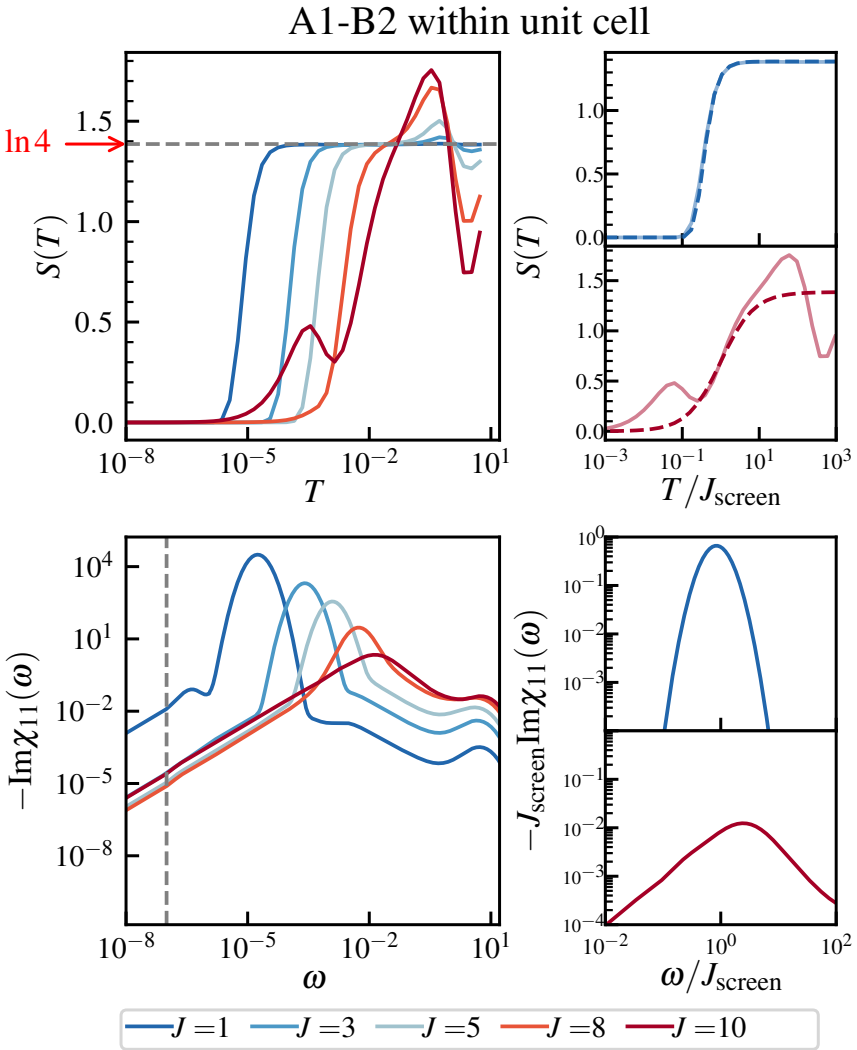
pair	competing regimes
A2–A2	FM / LM
A2–B1	AFM / LM
A1–B2	AFM / Kondo
B2–B2	FM / Kondo



- free moment (A2/B1)
- Kondo (A1/B2)
- AFM singlet (A1–B2)

Only A1–B2 and B2–B2 have a nontrivial RKKY–Kondo competition

A1–B2: an AFM singlet at weak J crosses over to Kondo screening



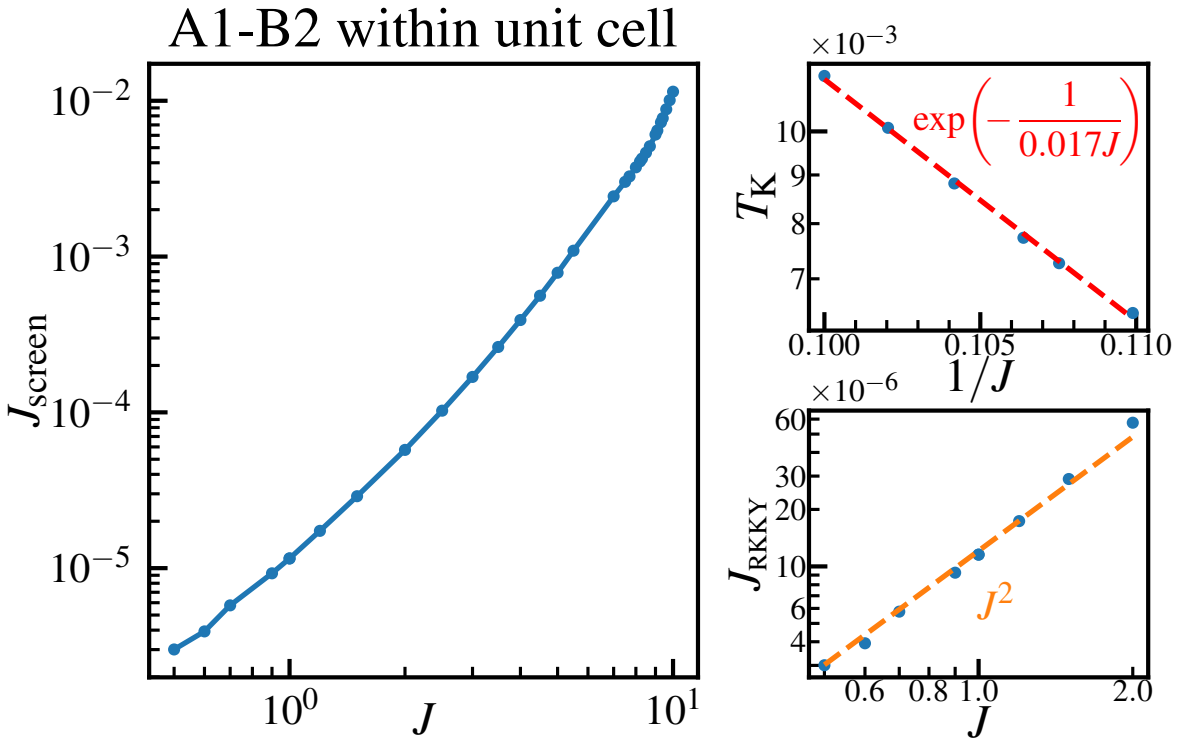
Weak J: entropy $\ln 4 \to 0$ via $\ln 2$, effective two-spin model $J_{\mathrm{RKKY}}\mathbf{S}_1\cdot\mathbf{S}_2$

Strong J: two independent Kondo screenings

Both limits follow universal curves

Antiferromagnetic locking and Kondo screening compete at one scale

The screening scale goes from J^2 (RKKY) to $e^{-1/J}$ (Kondo)



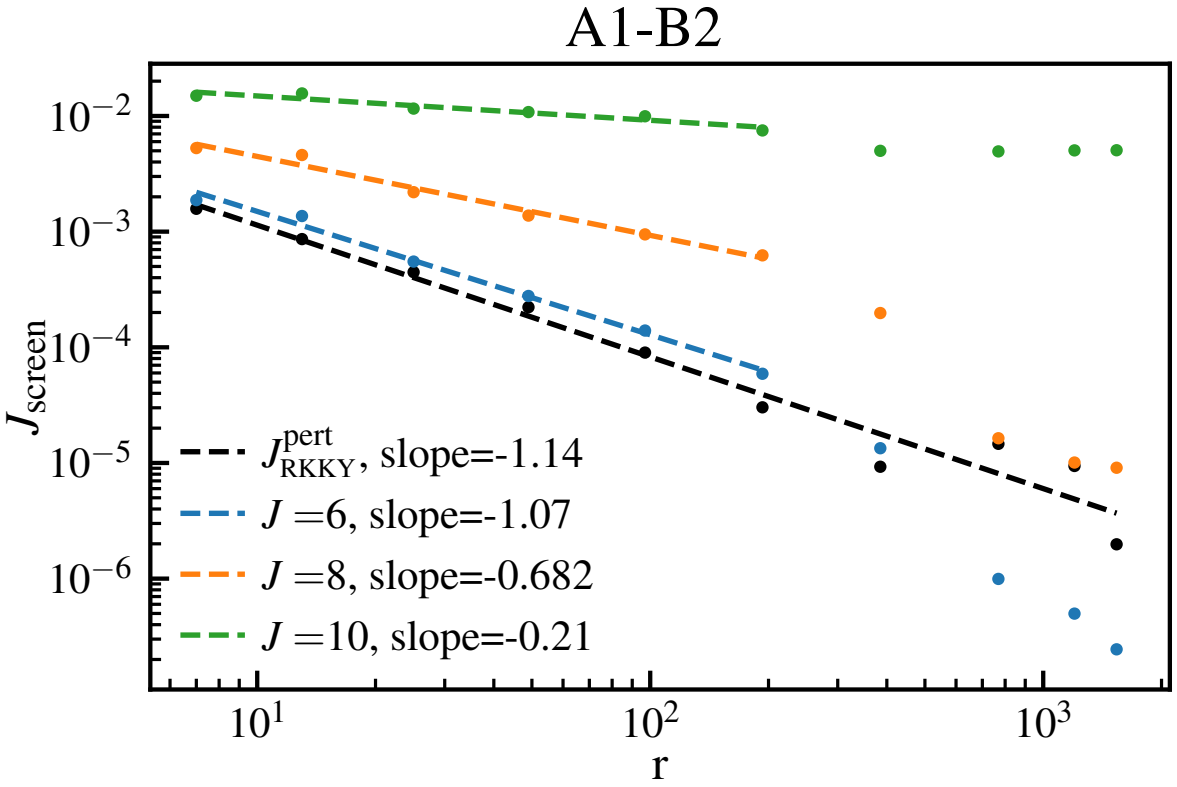
Weak J: $J_{\mathrm{screen}} \propto J^2$

Strong J: $\propto e^{-1/J}$

Insets confirm both laws

Same configuration, two regimes: the competition is non-perturbative

The distance dependence flattens from -1.14 to -0.21 with coupling



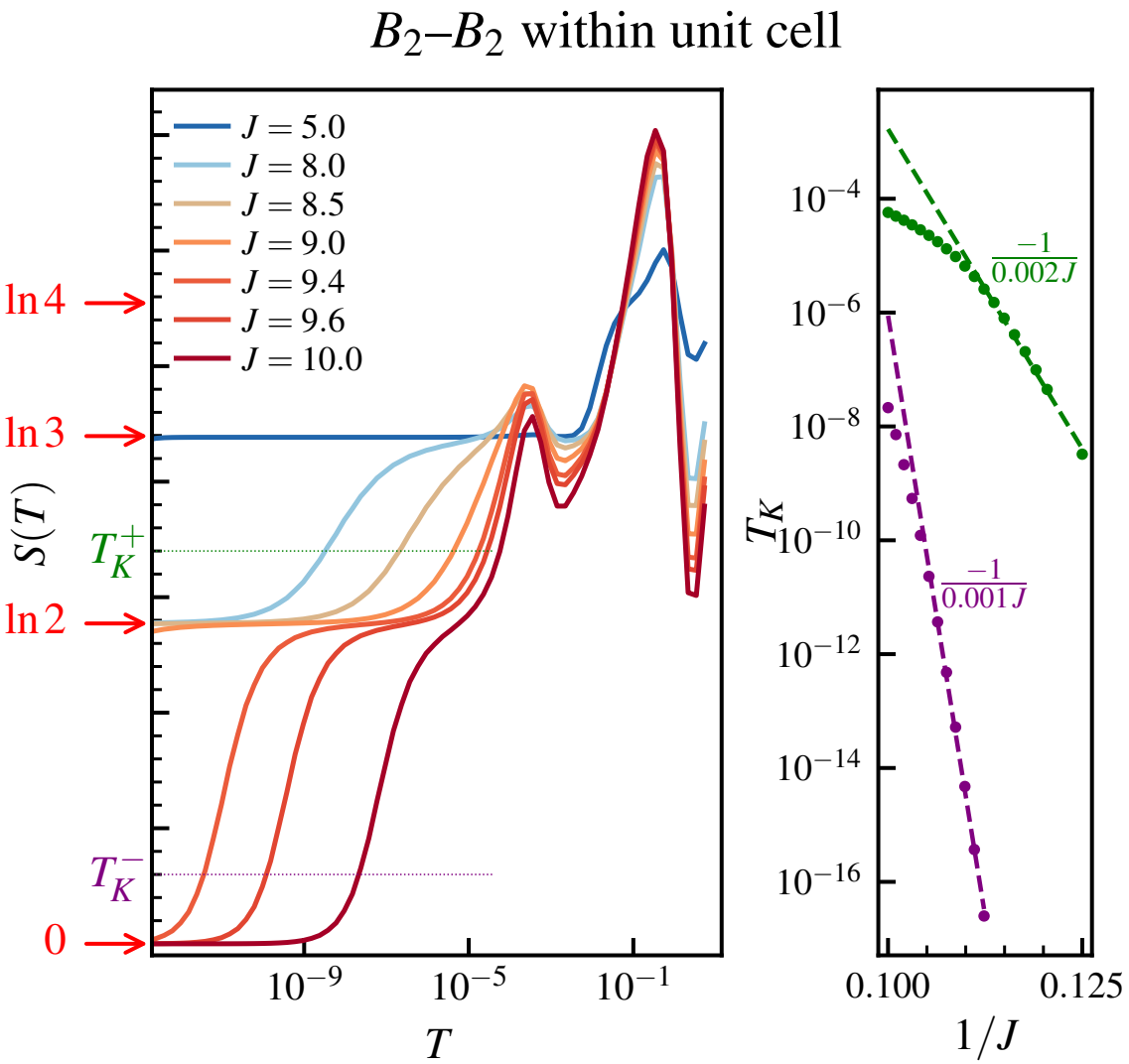
Perturbative RKKY: slope -1.14

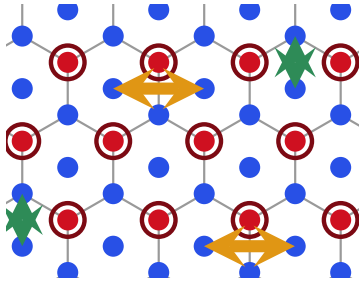
$J = 10$: slope -0.21

Strong coupling approaches the dilute Kondo limit

At strong coupling the impurities barely feel each other

B2–B2: an FM lock leads to two-stage Kondo screening





- free moment (A2/B1)
- Kondo (A1/B2)
- AFM singlet (A1–B2)
- FM two-stage (B2–B2)

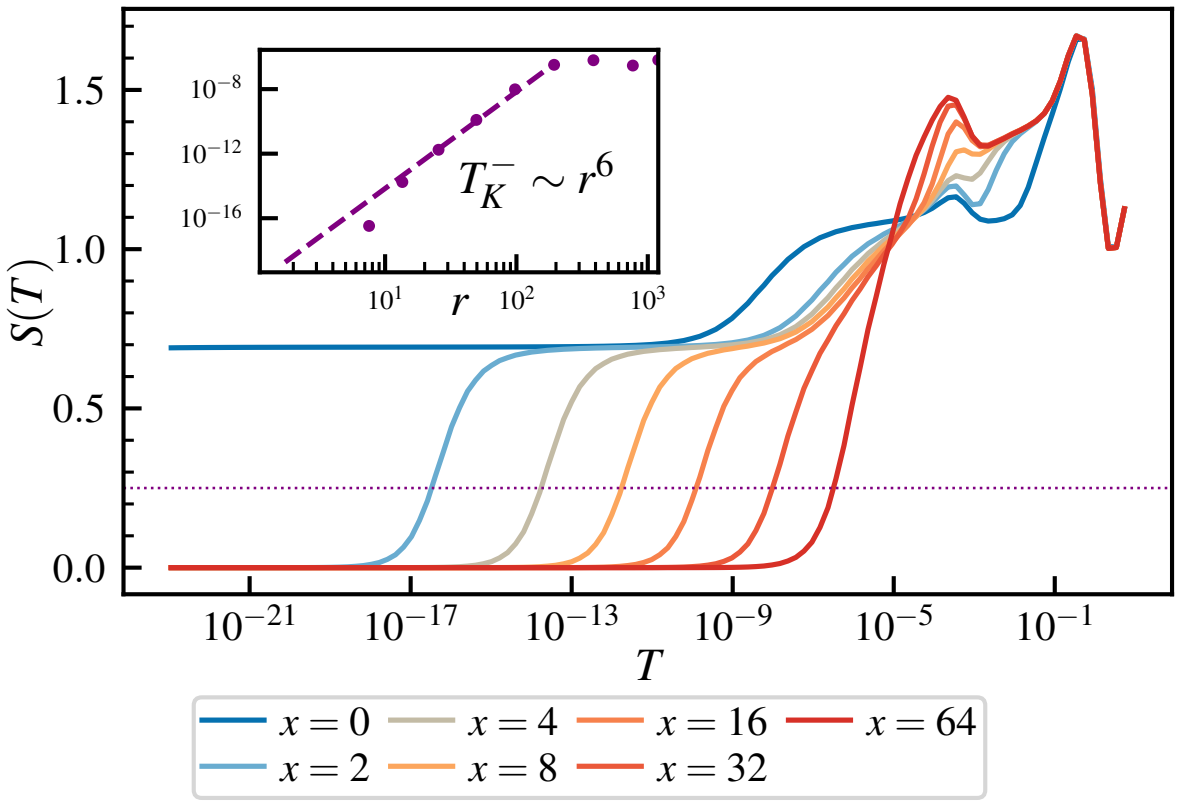
$\ln 4 \to \ln 3$ (FM spin-1)

$\to \ln 2$ (underscreened, T_K^+)

$\to 0$ (singlet, T_K^-)

Entropy plateaus: $\ln 4 \to \ln 3 \to \ln 2 \to 0$

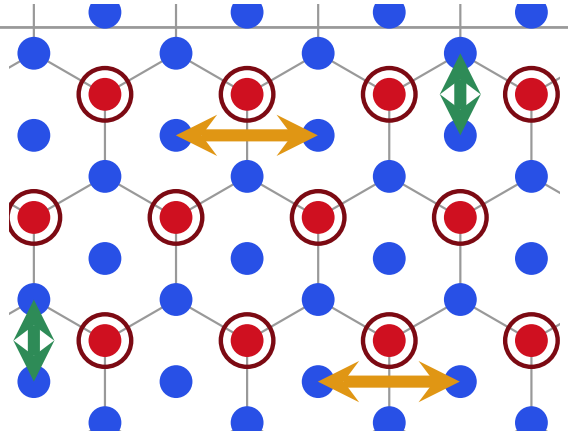
With distance the two Kondo scales merge into the dilute limit



- $T_K^{\pm}$ approach each other as r grows
- Two-stage structure needs a sizeable FM RKKY
- Dilute limit recovered smoothly

Two-stage screening is strongest for close impurities

One host, every screening regime: the impurity position selects it



- free moment (A2/B1)
- Kondo (A1/B2)
- AFM singlet (A1–B2)
- FM two-stage (B2–B2)

Stacked: free moment, never screened

Unstacked: Kondo, AFM singlet, FM two-stage

Position and pairing pick the regime

Outlook: STM on BLG, artificial impurity arrays, RKKY in TBG

Site selectivity: every Kondo regime in one sample

Backup: universal two-spin entropy curves

Antiferromagnetic, $J > 0$: $S(J{=}T) = \ln 3 + \ldots$ (universal function of $u = J/4T$)

Ferromagnetic, $J < 0$: spin-1 plateau, $S \to \ln 3$

Kondo: $S(T) \simeq \ln 2/(1 + T_K/T)$, with $S(T_K) = \frac{1}{2} \ln 2$

Backup: perturbative RKKY, sign from the NLDOS

$$\rho(\mathbf{r},\omega) = \rho_s(\mathbf{r},\omega) + \rho_a(\mathbf{r},\omega), \quad \rho_{s/a}(-\omega) = \pm\rho_{s/a}(\omega)$$

$J_{\mathrm{RKKY}} \propto J^2$ from the one-loop spin susceptibility

Positive denominator: sign set by the symmetric vs antisymmetric NLDOS

Same sublattice: symmetric dominates, FM; opposite: AFM

Backup: toy model, RKKY develops a logarithmic decay

